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la critique textuelle en ecoutant le texte : c'est-a-dire en partant de ce qu'il dit. Exemple grossier : s'il dit unanimement le bon manuscrit est celui qui contient mes 3 paraboles, on choisira ce manuscrit au depend des autres, pourquoi? parce que l'on est dirige par notre foi dans le texte.

11 + 10) back in the 5th century, as I suppose, being itself independent of all of them. In the apparatus I have already argued from the grammar and the context that περιπατουμεν is correct and therefore original—it is certainly ancient. If every word in an independent text-type is ancient it follows necessarily that the text-type itself is ancient.

--- *εν* 3:24 ℵ [30%]

Of the ten non-**f**[35] MSS listed by E*CM*, cursives 614 and 2412 represent one line. Cursive 1836 has only a third of the total, so I discount it. Codex ℵ gives overt 4th century attestation. Of the five Byzantine MSS, 607 and 2423 represent one line. So we are left with seven independent lines of transmission in the fifth century, aside from **f**[35], three of which are shared with column three and another with column two. This reading is certainly ancient and in my opinion is most probably original.

Conclusion

Obviously the picture we have seen so far will be true for all other **f**[35] minority readings, as we move up to 35%, 40%, etc. Allow me to repeat some salient points:

1. **f**[35] is early and independent—independent of <u>all</u> other known lines of transmission;
2. if it is independent of all other lines of transmission it must hark back to the Autographs, of necessity;
3. if every word in an independent text-type is ancient it follows necessarily that the text-type itself is ancient;
4. the surviving MSS from the first five centuries absolutely do not represent the true state of affairs at the time.

The spiritual aspect of NT textual criticism

I will discuss the subject under three headings: 1) the source of the problem; 2) the perpetuation of the problem; 3) a solution for the problem.

The source of the problem

There are only two spiritual kingdoms in this world. While the Sovereign Creator was walking this earth in the body of Jesus He declared: “He who is not with me is against me, and he who does not gather with me, scatters” (Luke 11:23, Matthew 12:30). Note that the Sovereign does not permit neutrality; either you are with Him or you are against Him (agnosticism is a passive rejection). Even what we do is not neutral; if we are not

gathering with Him, we are scattering. There is no third option. Whoever is not with Jesus is with Satan, automatically. This applies to everything in this life; how much more then to something so important as the transmission of the biblical Text. Satan's opposition to God has always included opposition to any word of His directed to the human race. It began in the Garden: "Has God indeed said?" (Genesis 3:1). It follows that to exclude the supernatural from one's model of NT textual criticism is to be fundamentally irresponsible (unless it is wittingly perverse).

Surely, because responsibility begins with presupposition, and you choose your presuppositions. The point is, textual criticism, of anything written, presupposes that the original wording of that writing has been lost, in the sense that no one knows what it might have been. No one does textual criticism on today's newspaper or last week's magazine. No one even does textual criticism on the first edition (1611) of the KJV, since a copy still exists. Most practitioners of NT textual criticism use some form of eclecticism, and they are responsible for having made that choice—they tacitly accepted the presuppositions upon which eclecticism is based.[1] Eclecticism is based on the following presuppositions: 1) the NT writings are not inspired (had they been inspired, they would have been preserved); 2) the early Christians did not recognize them as inspired; 3) therefore they did not concern themselves to protect and preserve those writings; 4) therefore the original wording was lost in the sense that no one knew for sure what it might have been; 5) it was only when the superstition and credulity of the Christians had elevated those writings to the condition of 'Scripture' (around 200 AD) that they began to concern themselves with protection and preservation, only by then it was too late; 6) therefore there was no 'normal transmission' of the NT writings until after the third century.

Such presuppositions reject the available evidence to the contrary. We have historical evidence to support the following statements: 1) the apostles knew they were writing Scripture; 2) the apostles knew that colleagues were writing Scripture; 3) their contemporary Christians immediately recognized that those writings were Scripture; 4) therefore, they were concerned with their protection and preservation (this is demonstrable); 5) the proliferation of well-made copies started right away; 6) there was a normal transmission of those writings from the beginning and down through the centuries; 7) thus, the original wording was never lost.

Why do people reject the evidence, or at least ignore it? Because Satan

[1] They may have been brainwashed, pressured into accepting something without understanding it, but that does not change the nature of the presuppositions. I will discuss this later.

blinds their minds, as is plainly stated in 2 Corinthians 4:3-4. “So where our Gospel has actually been concealed, it has been hidden from those who are being wasted, 4 among whom the god of this age has blinded the minds of the unbelieving, so that the light of the Gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God, should not dawn on them.”

The Text clearly states that Satan, "the god of this age", is in the business of blinding the minds of unbelievers when they hear the Gospel, so they won't understand, so they won't be convicted, so they won't repent and convert. This is a terrible truth, the most terrible truth in the world, at least as I see it. The enemy has access to our minds, access in the sense that he has the power or ability to invade them, whether by introducing thoughts or by jamming our reasoning. The Lord Jesus had already declared this truth previously, when He explained the parable of the sower. "These are the ones by the wayside where the word is sown; but, as soon as they hear it Satan comes and takes away the word that was planted in their hearts" (Mark 4:15). In the parallel passage in Luke 8:12 Jesus adds the following words: "lest they believe and be saved". Note that the Word is already in the mind or heart of the person, but then Satan comes, invades the mind and "takes away" that word. I am not sure just how this intrusion by the enemy works, perhaps he causes a mental block of some sort, but the practical effect is that the Word becomes ineffective, as if the person had not even heard it.[1]

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[1] The crucial question then becomes, what can we do about it? We find the answer in Mark 3:27. "No one can plunder the strong man's goods, invading his house, unless he first bind the strong man; then he may plunder his house." I have used the definite article with the first occurrence of ‘strong man’ because the Greek Text has it, the point being that this particular strong man has already been introduced in the immediate context. “The strong man” here is Satan. (The Jewish leaders tried to explain Jesus' authority over the demons by saying that He expelled them by the power of Beelzebub, prince of the demons. In His retort, Jesus does not waste time with that name but uses the enemy's proper name, Satan.)

So then, the Lord Jesus declares that it is impossible to steal Satan's goods unless we bind him first. (From His use of "no one", it seems clear that the Lord is enunciating a general principle or truth.) And what might the nature of those ‘goods’ be? In the context (see Matthew 12:22-24) Jesus had delivered someone from a demon that caused blindness and dumbness, and in their comments the scribes and Pharisees include other instances where Jesus had expelled demons—it seems clear that the "goods" are people who are subject to Satan's power, in one way or another. Thus we have the same essential truth as that declared in Acts 26:18—we have to do something about Satan's power over a person so that he or she can be saved! So what can we do? Since the point of handcuffs is to keep someone from acting, I believe that in so many words, aloud or in thought, we must forbid Satan from interfering in the minds of our hearers, before we preach. For more on this subject the reader may consult my site: www.prunch.org, or my book: *Essays, on Discipleship, Missions and Spiritual Warfare*, 2nd edition.

Consider also 1 John 5:19 that says that "the whole world lies in the malignant one". The verb 'to lie' here is used of lying on a bed—your entire weight is on the bed. A bed has no will, but Satan certainly does; the picture is one of control. The only way to escape this control is to surrender to Sovereign Jesus. Until you belong to Jesus, you remain in the world controlled by Satan.

Further, in addition to not permitting neutrality, Sovereign Jesus was strict about the requirements for identifying with Him. "Whoever is ashamed of me and **my words** in this adulterous and sinful generation, the Son of the Man will also be ashamed of him whenever He comes in the glory of His Father with the holy angels." (Mark 8:38 and Luke 9:26). We are not allowed to be ashamed of the words that Jesus spoke; it is mandatory to agree with what He taught. Surely, because we will be judged by those words. "The one who rejects me and does not receive my sayings has that which judges him—the word that I have spoken, that is what will judge him on the last day;[1] because I have not spoken on my own, but the Father who sent me, He gave me a command, what I should say and what I should speak" (John 12:48-49). So how can those words judge you? They will judge you based on what you did with them. But how can they judge you? They can judge you because they are living (Hebrews 4:12, 1 Peter 1:23, Acts 7:38). Any word delivered by the Sovereign Creator will be authoritative.

2 John 9 goes in the same direction: "Anyone who turns aside and does not continue in the teaching of Christ does not have God". If you turn aside, you are out. "Does not continue" can only refer to someone who has been 'in'. To continue in His teaching is to agree with Him. How can you have "the mind of Christ" (1 Corinthians 2:16) without thinking like He does?

So what is the point? The point is the following: Sovereign Jesus was adamant about the inspiration and preservation of the OT; and once glorified He was more than emphatic about the NT (Revelation 22:18-19). Although He was presumably referring specifically to the Apocalypse, we may reasonably extend the warning to the whole NT, based on the belief that all of the books of the NT are inspired. Anyone who does not think like Jesus does with regard to the inspiration and preservation of the Holy Scriptures is on the other side. The world in which we live is no longer 'post-modern', it is becoming increasingly anti-Christian. In North America and Europe people have already been put in prison for preaching what

[1] 'Ignorance of the law is no excuse.' If the Bible exists in your language and you know how to read (or you know someone who can read), then you could have learned Jesus' sayings. Claiming that you didn't know won't hack it.

the Bible says. To spend eternity in the Lake of Fire is the price you will pay for being 'politically correct' in today's world.

In John 8:44 the Sovereign declared that Satan is "the father of lying", and that "there is no truth in him". According to Hebrew idiomatic usage, the 'son' of something is characterized by that something. It follows that to be the 'father' of something is to be the owner of that something. Several times Jesus called the Holy Spirit "the Spirit of the Truth" (John 14:17, 15:26, 16:13). So, all truth belongs to the Holy Spirit, and all falsehood belongs to Satan. It follows that whenever someone lies, he will be serving Satan. And whenever someone embraces a lie (such as evolutionism, Marxism, humanism, relativism, Hortianism, etc.), he will be giving Satan a bridgehead in his mind, which Satan will try to develop into a stronghold. A stronghold of Satan on a given subject does not allow one to think freely about that subject. The person is forced to stay with the lie. (The only way out is for someone with the power of God to come and nullify the stronghold.)

It follows that as long as someone is teaching falsehood, he is serving Satan. Yes, because God "cannot lie" (Titus 1:2), since it is contrary to His essence; He cannot deny Himself (2 Timothy 2:13). Since no lie is of God, and there are only two sides, any lie is of Satan. Attention please: what someone thinks does not change reality. Saul of Tarsus thought he was serving God by persecuting Christians; only in fact he was serving Satan. Since eclectic textual criticism is based on falsehoods, it belongs to Satan. People who think that NT textual criticism is a grey area where anyone can have his 'jumps' are in for a rather nasty surprise. Just by the way, in today's world people are buying the idea that you create your own 'truth'. If something is 'your truth', no one else has the right to challenge it. Since all real truth is God's truth, there is no such thing as 'your truth', there is only 'your falsehood'. The truth is not democratic, it is not determined by human vote or opinion. The truth **is**.

Ephesians 2:2 states that Satan is "the spirit who is now at work in the sons of the disobedience". This spirit is presently at work (present tense) in 'the sons of the disobedience'. 'Sons' of something are characterized by that something, and the something in this case is 'the' disobedience (the Text has the definite article)—a continuation of the original rebellion against the Sovereign of the universe. Anyone in rebellion against the Creator is under satanic influence, direct or indirect (in most cases a demon acts as Satan's agent, since he is not omnipresent, when something more than the influence of the surrounding culture is required; that includes the academic culture). Anyone in rebellion against the Creator will also have strongholds of Satan in his mind. Of a certainty. If I am not mistaken, all editions of the Greek NT published by the United Bible

Societies were produced by 'sons of the disobedience', and Satan did not miss the opportunity.

Yes, but how can we know who is a son of the disobedience? Sovereign Jesus explained one way in Matthew 7:15-20:

> "Beware of false prophets who come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly they are ravenous wolves.[1] 16 You will know them by their fruits. Do people gather grapes from thorn bushes, or figs from thistles? 17 Just so, every good tree produces good fruits, but the rotten tree produces evil fruits.[2] 18 A good tree cannot produce evil fruits, nor can a rotten tree produce good fruits. 19 So every tree not producing good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire.[3] 20 Therefore, you will know them by their fruits."

Exactly; just pay attention to the results of their work. Since the editors of the UBS editions foisted errors of fact and obvious contradictions on their texts, the result has been a constant weakening of confidence in the NT's integrity and reliability. Equally pernicious are the footnotes in many modern versions whose real purpose is to undermine confidence in the biblical text. Whoever undermines confidence in the biblical text is serving Satan. Just look at the 'fruits'. What a person does reflects what he believes. Also, if you have the Holy Spirit, and know how to listen to Him, you can ask Him about specific cases.

It has always been standard procedure for Satan and his servants to attack strong arguments in favor of the truth as if they were weak and wrong.[4] To give one example, John William Burgon attacked the W-H theory and text, based on objective evidence, but he also defended the Textus Receptus, that he called the Traditional Text, citing divine providence. The academic world severely ignored the objective evidence and vehemently attacked what they called Burgon's 'theological' argument. They demonized 'theological' argument and created a psychosis on that subject. What is the strongest possible argument in support of the biblical Text? Precisely that God inspired it and then preserved it! So Satan energized his servants to do all in their power to exclude the supernatural from the discipline.

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[1] Probably demonized; demonic prophecies are always destructive.

[2] The Lord used 'rotten' and 'evil' (or 'malignant') because He was really talking about people, not trees.

[3] The Lord is very clear about the eternal destiny of people who do not produce good fruit. Remember Ephesians 2:8-10—we are not saved by good works, but we are indeed saved for good works; if we do not produce, we are not saved.

[4] In today's world, take a hard look at any 'principle' or 'law' that Satan is using, such as 'everything is relative' or 'hate speech'. It is the opposite that will be true.

Their procedure was totally perverse, satanic, because Burgon's 'theological' argument was in reality a statement of his presuppositions, which he stated openly, as any true scholar should. It is impossible to work without presuppositions, but they attacked Burgon for even having them! They were perverse because they pretended that they did not have presuppositions, and of course they failed to state them. That is dirty.

And then there are the canards, falsehoods that have acquired the status of 'fact' within the discipline. It has been standard fare within the discipline to refer to the Byzantine text as being a 'controlled text'. Whether or not that would be a good thing would depend on who did the controlling. But the idea is clearly presented as being a negative factor because it is used to 'justify' neglecting the Byzantine MSS. So far as I know, those who use the idea as a negative factor have never identified who did the controlling. However, if a text is 'controlled', someone has to do the controlling—if there is no control**er**, there can be no control**ing**. So who are the possible candidates? I see three possibilities: human beings, Satan, God.

So far as I know, all those who refer to the Byzantine text as 'controlled' exclude the supernatural from their model; so for them the controlling is done by human beings, independent of supernatural influence. Since the alleged control had to operate for more than a millennium, it could not be done by a single individual. But who could control the whole Mediterranean world? For over a thousand years the Roman Church used Latin, not Greek. Was there ever a functioning central authority among the Orthodox Churches? Certainly not for a thousand years, and not for the whole Mediterranean world. So who did the controlling?

Not only that, but the supposed controlling was evidently rather lax, since the MSS are full of random mistakes, quite apart from shared dependencies. Consider the conclusion reached by F. Wisse after he collated and analyzed 1,386 Greek MSS containing chapters 1, 10 and 20 of Luke (three complete chapters). He described 37 lines of transmission, plus 89 "mavericks", MSS so individually disparate that they could not be grouped. Of the 37 groups, 36 fall within the broad Byzantine river, and within them Wisse described 70 subgroups. So what kind of 'control' could permit such a situation? I trust that my readers will not think me unreasonable when I say that in the face of such concrete evidence I find the thesis of a 'controlled' Byzantine text (excluding the supernatural) to be less than convincing. But then, how shall we account for the comparative uniformity found within it?

My readers should be aware that I personally insist that the supernatural should be included in any model of NT textual criticism. Both God and

Satan certainly exist, and both have an ongoing interest in the fortunes of the NT Text. For some time I have been defending the divine preservation of the NT Text in concrete terms. Curiously, those who allege a controlled Byzantine text usually reject any notion of divine preservation. But of course, if they do not believe in divine inspiration, they will not believe in preservation. Someone who denies the existence of a Sovereign Creator will logically insist that a nonexistent being cannot do anything. But how then can such a person explain the Byzantine text? I submit that no naturalistic hypothesis can account for Family 35 (**K**^{r}).

Satan would certainly do nothing to help preserve the NT Text; any involvement of his would be with a view to pervert the text, thereby undermining its authority. (I would say that he concentrated his efforts in Egypt, and he uses his servants within the academic community to control the so-called 'critical' texts.) I have argued elsewhere that the transmission of the NT Text was predominately 'normal', and that normality was defined by the Christian Church. Why were copies made? Because the congregations needed them. Why did the congregations 'need' them? Because they understood that the NT writings were divinely inspired, and they were read and discussed in their weekly meetings. To argue that the early Christians were mistaken in that understanding would be beside the point. That understanding (mistaken or not) determined their attitude toward the NT writings, which controlled their production of copies. If the majority of persons producing copies was made up of sincere (more or less) Christians, they would do their work with reasonable care (some more, some less). Those who held a strong view of inspiration would be especially careful.

I submit that the surviving MSS reflect my description above. **f**^{35} (**K**^{r}), by far the largest and most cohesive group (perhaps the only group that exists in all 27 books), represents the core of the transmission, its representatives having been produced by copyists with a high view of inspiration (as evidenced by the extreme care in their work). Outside that core are a large number of tangents, or rivulets, that diverge from the core in varying degrees, and that began at different times and places. A monk who was merely carrying out a religious obligation would produce a 'run of the mill' Byzantine copy; good enough for virtually all practical purposes, but not up to the **f**^{35} standard.

So was the Byzantine text 'controlled'? Obviously not in any strict sense. The control was exercised by a common belief (within the Christian community) that the NT was divinely inspired. It was that belief that dictated the proliferation of copies made with reasonable care. That reasonable care is reflected in the basic uniformity within the Byzantine bulk. But to explain the incredibly careful transmission reflected in the **f**^{35}

representatives requires something more.

Of **f**[35] MSS that I myself have collated, I hold perfect copies of the family archetype (empirically determined) as follows: 29 for Philemon, 15 for 2 Thessalonians, 9 for Titus, 6 for Galatians, 4 for Ephesians, 2 for Matthew, and at least one for 22 of the 27 NT books (and many more are off by a single letter!). These are MSS from all over the Mediterranean world, and representing five centuries (XI, XII, XIII, XIV, XV). So what kind of control could produce such an incredible level of perfection—a control exercised in isolated monasteries scatted around the Mediterranean world and during five centuries? We know of no human agency that could do it. If the agency was not human, then it had to be divine. Is Family 35 a controlled text? Yes. Controlled by whom? By the Holy Spirit.

Things like 'controlled text' and 'ecclesiastical imposition', also the falsehood that the bulk of the extant Greek MSS have a late text, have been used to discourage people from studying the vast bulk of the MSS. The 'harder' and 'shorter' reading 'canons' are plainly false, as anyone who has studied actual MSS knows. To hide the fact that the oldest MSS are of demonstrably poor quality, eclecticists have stridently insisted that 'oldest equals best', and so on into the night. The discipline of New Testament textual criticism is a veritable stagnant swamp; yes indeed, a veritable stagnant swamp.

The perpetuation of the problem

Those who are in open rebellion against God and His written Revelation will simply continue to do what they can against both. That is a given. But what about those who claim to believe in God and His Word, and may think that they really do, and yet have embraced falsehood with reference to the NT Text? How did they get that way?

The discipline of NT textual criticism, as we know it, is basically a 'child' of Western Europe and its colonies; the Eastern Orthodox Churches have generally not been involved. (They have always known that the true NT Text lies within the Byzantine tradition.) In the year 1500 the Christianity of Western Europe was dominated by the Roman Catholic Church, whose pope claimed the exclusive right to interpret Scripture. That Scripture was the Latin Vulgate, which the laity was not allowed to read. Only priests were allowed to read it, and only the pope could interpret it. Martin Luther's ninety-five theses were posted in 1517. Was it mere chance that the first printed Greek Text of the NT was published the year before?

As the Protestant Reformation advanced, it was declared that the authority of Scripture exceeded that of the pope, and that every believer had the right to read and interpret the Scriptures for himself. The authority of the

Latin Vulgate was also challenged, since the NT was written in Greek. Of course the Vatican library held many Greek MSS, no two of which were identical (at least in the Gospels), so the Roman Church challenged the authenticity of the Greek Text.[1] In short, the Roman Church forced the Reformation to come to grips with textual variation among the Greek MSS. But they did not know how to go about it, because this was a new field of study and they simply were not in possession of a sufficient proportion of the relevant evidence. (They probably didn't even know that the Mt. Athos peninsula, with its twenty monasteries, existed.)

Family 35, being by far the largest and most cohesive group of MSS with a demonstrable archetype, was poorly represented in the libraries of Western Europe. For that matter, very few MSS of whatever text-type had been sufficiently collated to allow for any tracing of the transmissional history. Worse, the lack of complete collations made it impossible to refute an erroneous hypothesis within a reasonable time frame. (Lamentably, that lack has not been completely remedied until this day.)

In 1500 the Roman Catholic Establishment was corrupt, morally bankrupt, and discredited among thinking people. The Age of Reason and humanism were coming to the fore. More and more people were deciding that they could do better without the god of the Roman Establishment. The new imagined freedom from supernatural supervision was intoxicating, and many had no interest in accepting the authority of Scripture (*sola Scriptura*). Further, it would be naive in the extreme to exclude the supernatural from consideration, and not allow for satanic activity behind the scenes.

Consider Ephesians 2:2—"in which you once walked, according to the Aeon of this world, the ruler of the domain of the air, the spirit who is now at work in the sons of the disobedience." Strictly speaking, the Text has "according to the Aeon of this world, according to the ruler of the domain of the air"—the phrases are parallel, so 'Aeon' and 'ruler' have the same referent, a specific person or being. This spirit is presently at work (present tense) in 'the sons of the disobedience'. 'Sons' of something are those characterized by that something, and the something in this case is 'the' disobedience (the Text has the definite article)—a continuation of the original rebellion against the Sovereign of the universe. 'Sons of the disobedience' joined the attack against Scripture. The so-called 'higher criticism' denied divine inspiration altogether.[2] Others used the

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[1] Probably no two MSS of the Latin Vulgate are identical either, but that was not the issue. Indeed, so far as I know, there is no way to establish what may have been the original wording of the Latin Vulgate, in every detail.

[2] The Darwinian theory appeared to be made to order for those who wished to get rid of

textual variation to argue that in any case the original wording was 'lost', there being no objective way to determine what it may have been (unfortunately, no one was able to perceive such a way at that time).

The uncritical assumption that 'oldest equals best' was an important factor, and became increasingly so as earlier uncials came to light. Appeal was made to the analogy of a stream, where the purest water would presumably be that closest to the source. But with reference to NT manuscripts the analogy is fallacious, and becomes a sophistry. There is general agreement that most of the serious corruption suffered by the NT text happened during the second century, before our earliest MSS. So age is no guarantee.

Both Codex Vaticanus and Codex Bezae were available early on, and they have thousands of disagreements between themselves, just in the Gospels (in Acts, Bezae is wild almost beyond belief). **If** 'oldest equals best', and the oldest MSS are in constant and massive disagreement between/among themselves, then the recovery of a lost text becomes hopeless. Did you get that? **Hopeless, totally hopeless**! However, I have argued (and continue to do so) that 'oldest equals worst', and that changes the picture radically. The benchmark work on this subject is Herman C. Hoskier's *Codex B and its Allies: A Study and an Indictment* (2 vols.; London: Bernard Quaritch, 1914). The first volume (some 500 pages) contains a detailed and careful discussion of hundreds of obvious errors in Codex B; the second (some 400 pages) contains the same for Codex Aleph. He affirms that in the Gospels alone these two MSS differ well over 3,000 times, which number does not include minor errors such as spelling (II, 1). [Had he tabulated all differences, the total would doubtless increase by several hundreds.]

Well now, simple logic demands that one or the other has to be wrong those 3,000+ times; they cannot both be right, quite apart from the times when they are both wrong. **No amount of subjective preference can obscure the fact that they are poor copies, objectively so**.[1] They were

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a Creator, or any superior Authority, who might require an accounting. The 'higher criticism' served the purpose of getting rid of an authoritative Revelation, that might be used to require an accounting. Rebels don't like to be held accountable.

[1] John William Burgon personally collated what in his day were 'the five old uncials' (ℵ,A,B,C,D). Throughout his works he repeatedly calls attention to the *concordia discors*, the prevailing confusion and disagreement, that the early uncials display among themselves. Luke 11:2-4 offers one example.

> "The five Old Uncials" (ℵABCD) falsify the Lord's Prayer as given by St. Luke in no less than forty-five words. But so little do they agree among themselves, that they throw themselves into six different combinations in their departures from the Traditional Text; and yet they are never able to agree among themselves as to one single various reading: while only once are more than two of them

so bad that no one could stand to use them, and so they survived physically. But they had no 'children', since no one wanted to copy them. I would say that they were fabricated, not being true copies of any exemplar. In that case, they do not belong to any line of transmission.

Since everyone is influenced (not necessarily controlled) by his milieu, this was also true of the Reformers. In part (at least) the Reformation was a 'child' of the Renaissance, with its emphasis on reason. Recall that on trial Luther said he could only recant if convinced by Scripture and reason. So far so good, but many did not want Scripture, and that left only reason. Further, since reason cannot explain or deal with the supernatural, those who emphasize reason are generally unfriendly toward the supernatural. [To this day the so-called historic or traditional Protestant denominations have trouble dealing with the supernatural.]

Before Adolf Deissmann published his *Light from the Ancient East* (1910), (being a translation of *Licht vom Osten*, 1908), wherein he demonstrated that Koine Greek was the *lingua franca* in Jesus' day, there even being a published grammar explaining its rules, only classical Greek was taught in the universities. But the NT was written in Koine. Before Deissmann's benchmark work, there were two positions on the NT Greek: 1) it was a debased form of classical Greek, or 2) it was a 'Holy Ghost' Greek, invented for the NT. The second option was held mainly by pietists; the academic world preferred the first, which raised the natural question: if God were going to inspire a NT, why would He not do it in 'decent' Greek? The prevailing idea that Koine was bad Greek predisposed many against the NT.

All of this placed the defenders of an inspired Greek Bible on the defensive, with the very real problem of deciding where best to set up a perimeter they could defend. Given the prevailing ignorance concerning the relevant evidence, their best choice appeared to be an appeal to Divine Providence. God providentially chose the TR, so that was the text to be used (the 'traditional' text).[1] I would say that Divine Providence was indeed at work, because the TR is a good Text, far better than the eclectic ones currently in vogue.

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observed to stand together, and their grand point of union is no less than an omission of the article. Such is their eccentric tendency, that in respect of thirty-two out of the whole forty-five words they bear in turn solitary evidence. (*The Traditional Text of the Holy Gospels Vindicated and Established*. Arranged, completed, and edited by Edward Miller. London: George Bell and Sons, 1896, p. 84.)

Yes indeed, oldest equals worst.

[1] Please note that I am not criticizing Burgon and others; they did what they could, given the information available to them. They knew that the Hortian theory and resultant Greek text could not be right.

To all appearances Satan was winning the day, but he still had a problem: the main Protestant versions (in German, English, Spanish, etc.) were all based on the *Textus Receptus*, as were doctrinal statements and 'prayer books'. Enter F.J.A. Hort, a quintessential 'son of the disobedience'. Hort did not believe in the divine inspiration of the Bible, nor in the divinity of Jesus Christ. Since he embraced the Darwinian theory as soon as it appeared, he presumably did not believe in God.[1] His theory of NT textual criticism, published in 1881,[2] was based squarely on the presuppositions that the NT was not inspired, that no special care was afforded it in the early decades, and that in consequence the original wording was lost—lost beyond recovery, at least by objective means, and that got rid of any objective authority for that text. Of course, because any text defined by subjective criteria will always be inherently subjective. His theory swept the academic world and continues to dominate the discipline to this day.[3]

But just how was it that the Hortian theory was able to take over the Greek departments of the conservative schools in North America? The answer begins with the onslaught of liberal theology upon the Protestant churches of that continent at the beginning of the twentieth century. The great champion of the divine inspiration of Scripture was Benjamin B. Warfield, a Presbyterian. His defense of inspiration is so good that it is

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[1] For documentation of all this, and a good deal more besides, in Hort's own words, please see the biography written by his son. A.F. Hort, *Life and Letters of Fenton John Anthony Hort* (2 vols.; London: Macmillan and Co. Ltd., 1896). The son made heavy use of the father's plentiful correspondence, whom he admired. (In those days a two-volume 'Life', as opposed to a one-volume 'Biography', was a posthumous status symbol, albeit of little consequence to the departed.) Many of my readers were taught, as was I, that one must not question/judge someone else's motives. But wait just a minute; where did such an idea come from? It certainly did not come from God, who expects the spiritual person to evaluate everything (1 Corinthians 2:15). Since there are only two spiritual kingdoms in this world (Matthew 6:24, 12:30; Luke 11:23, 16:13), then the idea comes from the other side. By eliminating motive, one also eliminates presupposition, which is something that God would never do, since presupposition governs interpretation (Matthew 22:29, Mark 12:24). Which is why we should always expect a true scholar to state his presuppositions. I have repeatedly stated mine, but here they are again: 1) The Sovereign Creator of the universe exists; 2) He delivered a written revelation to the human race; 3) He has preserved that revelation intact to this day.

[2] B.F. Westcott and F.J.A. Hort, *The New Testament in the Original Greek* (2 Vols.; London: Macmillan and Co., 1881). The second volume explains the theory, and is generally understood to be Hort's work.

[3] For a thorough discussion of that theory, please see chapters 3 and 4 above. Those chapters are little different from what they were in 1977, when I published the first edition. It has been over forty-five years, and so far as I know, no one has refuted my dismantling of Hort's theory. It has not been for lack of desire. Nowadays one frequently hears the argument that to criticize Hort is to flay a dead horse, since now the ruling paradigm is eclecticism (whether 'reasoned' or 'rigorous'). But eclecticism is based squarely on the same false presuppositions, and is therefore equally wrong.

difficult to improve it. Somewhere along the line, however, he decided to go to Germany to study; I believe it was at Tubingen. When he returned, he was thanking God for having raised up Westcott and Hort to restore the text of the New Testament (think about the implication of 'restore'). One of his students, Archibald T. Robertson, a Baptist, followed Warfield's lead. The prestige of those two men was so great that their view swept the theological schools of the continent. I solicit the patience of the reader while I try to diagnose what happened to Warfield in Tubingen.

At Tubingen Warfield found himself among enemies of an inspired Bible. Now he was a champion of divine inspiration, but for an inspired text to have objective authority today, it must have been preserved.[1] Given the prevailing ignorance concerning the relevant evidence at that time, Warfield was simply not able to defend preservation in objective terms (and neither was anyone else—this is crucial to understanding what happened). He was faced with the fact of widespread variation between and among the extant Greek manuscripts. Even worse—far worse—was the presupposition that 'oldest equals best', because the oldest manuscripts are hopelessly at odds among themselves. For example: the two great early codices, Vaticanus and Sinaiticus, differ between themselves well over 3,000 times just in the four Gospels. Well now, they cannot both be right; one or the other **has** to be wrong, quite apart from the places where they are both wrong. So what was poor Warfield to do? Enter Westcott and Hort. Hort claimed that as a result of their work only a thousandth part of the NT text could be considered to be in doubt, and this was joyfully received by the rank and file, since it seemed to provide assurance about the reliability of that text—however, of course, that claim applied only to the W-H text (probably the worst published NT in existence to this day, so the claim was false).[2] Warfield grasped at this like a drowning man grasps at a straw, thereby doing serious damage to North American Evangelicalism.[3]

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[1] This has always been a favorite argument with enemies of inspiration; it goes like this: "If God had inspired a text, He would have preserved it (or else why bother inspiring). He did not preserve the NT; therefore He did not inspire it." I confess that I am inclined to agree with that logical connection, except that I am prepared to turn the tables. I believe I can demonstrate that God did in fact preserve the NT Text; therefore He must have inspired it!

[2] I would say that their text is mistaken with reference to 10% of the words—the Greek NT has roughly 140,000 words, so the W-H text is mistaken with reference to 14,000 of them. I would say that the so-called 'critical' (read 'eclectic') text currently in vogue is 'only' off with reference to some 12,000, an improvement (small though it be). And just by the way, how wise is it to use a NT prepared by a servant (or servants) of Satan? (On the other hand, I claim that God has preserved the original wording to such an extent that we can, and do, know what it is, based on objective evidence.)

[3] However, I should not be unduly harsh in my criticism of Warfield; no one else knew

To understand the full impact of the onslaught of liberal theology, one must take account of the milieu. Reason has always been important to the historic or traditional Protestant denominations. In consequence, academic respectability has always been important to their graduate schools of theology. The difficulty resides in the following circumstance: for at least two centuries academia has been dominated by Satan, and so the terms of 'respectability' are dictated by him. Those terms include 'publish or perish', but of course he controls the technical journals. Since he is the father of lies (John 8:44), anyone who wished to tell the whole truth has always had a hard time getting an article published, no matter how good it was. To get an article published one had to toe the party line. 'Taking account of the existing literature' obliges one to waste a great deal of time reading the nonsense (when not deliberate falsehoods) produced by Satan's servants, all of which was designed to keep the reader away from the truth. One other thing: academic learning feeds pride, not the spirit. No graduate school of theology teaches how to hear the Holy Spirit. At the very beginning Satan placed himself at the 'tree of knowledge', and he remained there; he has never left it. And he is the enemy of the truth.

The TRUTH—aye, there's the rub. Consider 2 Thessalonians 2:9-12: "The coming of the *lawless one* is according to the working of Satan, with all power, signs, and lying wonders, 10 and with all unrighteous deception among those who perish, because they did not receive the love of the truth, that they might be saved. 11 And for this reason God will send them strong delusion, that they should believe the lie, 12 that they all may be condemned who did not believe the truth, but had pleasure in unrighteousness" (NKJV). Although verse ten is in the context of the activity of the Antichrist, who will find an easy target in 'those who are wasting themselves' (my translation), it does not follow that no one will be wasting himself before that activity. Obviously, people have been wasting themselves all down through history, and the underlying cause for that 'wasting' has never changed: "they did not receive the love of the truth". (It began in the Garden.)

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what to do either. The cruel fact was that the relevant evidence did not exist in usable form at that time. (It follows that any defense of divine preservation at that time had to be based upon faith, faith that God would produce the evidence in His time.) Part of the damage produced by Hort's theory was its disdain for the vast bulk of later manuscripts—they were not worth the bother to collate and study. Since it is precisely those disdained MSS that furnish the necessary evidence, that soporific effect of Hort's theory delayed the availability of the relevant evidence for a century. I remember one day in class (in 1957), the professor filled his lungs and proclaimed with gusto: "Gentlemen, where B and Aleph agree, you have the original." The poor man had obviously never read Herman C. Hoskier's *Codex B and its Allies: A Study and an Indictment* (published in 1914).

Please notice carefully what is said here: it is God Himself who sends the strong delusion! And upon whom does He send it? Upon those who do not receive the love of the truth.[1] And what is the purpose of the strong delusion?—the condemnation of those who do not believe the truth. Dear me, this is heavy. Notice that the truth is **central** to anyone's salvation. This raises the necessary question: just what is meant by 'the truth'? In John 14:6 Sovereign Jesus declared Himself to be 'the truth'. Praying to the Father in John 17:17 He said, "Thy Word is truth". Once each in John chapters 14, 15 and 16 He referred to the third person of the Trinity as "the Spirit of the truth". Since the Son is back in Heaven at the Father's right hand, and the Spirit is not very perceptible to most of us, most of the time, and since the Word is the Spirit's sword (Ephesians 6:17), our main access to 'the truth' is through God's Word, the Bible. The Bible offers propositional truth, but we need the Holy Spirit to illumine that truth, and to have the Holy Spirit we must be adequately related to Sovereign Jesus.

Now then, for something to be received, it must be offered; one cannot believe in something he has never heard about (Romans 10:14). The use of the verb 'receive' clearly implies an act of volition on the part of those not receiving the truth; that love was offered or made available to them but they did not want it; they wanted to be able to lie and to entertain lies told by others. But the consequences of such a choice are terrible; they turned their back on salvation. I suspect that not many Christians in the so-called 'first world' really believe what Sovereign Jesus said in Matthew 7:14: those who find the way of Life are **few**! And do not forget Revelation 22:15; "whoever loves and practices a lie" is excluded from the heavenly City [any lie, including Hort's].[2] I will here consider the implications for a student entering a graduate school of theology, because of what happens if he becomes a professor, or NT scholar, in his turn.[3]

Most such students presumably come from an evangelical environment, and were doubtless taught that the Bible is God's Word, and therefore

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[1] Please note that it is not enough to merely 'accept' the truth; it is required that we <u>love</u> the truth. Satan tantalizes us with fame and fortune (on his terms, of course), so to love the truth requires determination.

[2] Help! "A lie" is rather general, open-ended. What happens if I accepted a lie without realizing that it was one? But the Text does not say 'accepts'; it says 'loves' and 'practices'. The implication is that the contrary evidence, to the lie, is available, but has been rejected, or deliberately ignored—the person sold himself to the lie.

[3] At the graduate level, a student has the responsibility to evaluate what is being taught—if it goes contrary to the Text, it should not be accepted. I remember one day in chapel, a visiting scholar was expounding Romans 10:9. He stated that the Greek Text plainly means "Jesus as Lord", but then went on to try to explain why the school didn't believe that. His effort was rather lame; so much so that I determined to delve into the question for myself.

inspired. Some may even have been taught verbal, plenary inspiration. However, in most theological schools you cannot get a job as a teacher if you do not agree to use the eclectic Greek text, with all that implies. (Just as you cannot get a teaching job in most universities unless you at least pretend to believe in evolution.) If the school is at least nominally conservative, they will still say that the Bible is inspired. But if a student brings up the question of the preservation of the text in class, there will be an uncomfortable silence. If it was preserved, no one knows what or where it is. The brainwashing has been so complete that many (most?) seminary graduates do not even know that there is any question about what they were taught. They were taught an eclecticism based on Hort's theory, and for them that is all there is.

But to go back to our student, he finds himself surrounded by professors whose job it is to destroy his faith in an inspired Bible with objective authority. Of course, presumably, very few such professors have ever thought in those terms (so they would object to my statement). They would say that they are just doing their job, doing what they are paid to do, without troubling themselves with the whys and wherefores.[1] But of course the student is not expecting that; he believes that his professors must be men of God, and so he is predisposed to believe them. Besides that predisposition (and it is powerful), what are the tools at their disposal for doing their job? Well, they have ridicule, sarcasm, brainwashing, peer pressure, the 'emperor's new clothes' gambit, and satanic assistance, for starters. (There may also be threats, failing grades, disciplinary actions, foul play, and so on—I write from experience.) Most of the terms above are self-explanatory, but some readers may not be familiar with the ancient myth about the emperor—it boils down to this: you don't want to admit that you can't 'see' it, when everyone else claims to be doing so. But by far the most serious is 'satanic assistance', and here I must needs go into detail.

Returning to 2 Thessalonians 2:10 and the 'love of the truth', as explained above, our main access to 'the truth' is through God's Word, the Bible. Our student may have gone to Sunday school, probably heard sermons with at least some biblical content, and certainly has his own copy of the Bible. In short, he has had, and continues to have, access to 'the truth'. However, the Holy Spirit does 'talk' to us, if we will listen. For example:

[1] For older, established scholars there is also the matter of pride and vested interest; who wants to admit that he has been wrong all his professional life? Then there is the doctrine of professional ethics, one must respect his colleagues (respect for the colleague trumps respect for the truth). [One must not ask where <u>that</u> doctrine came from.] One other thing: where a school or institution depends on financial help from outside, it will be threatened with the loss of that help, if it does not toe the line, and its very existence may depend on that help, so they cave in.

my father was born in 1906, and in due time went to Moody Bible Institute and Wheaton College. In those days the American Standard Version (ASV) was touted as the best thing since the Garden of Eden; it was 'the rock of biblical integrity', etc. etc. Now my father had the practice of reading through the entire Bible once a year, a practice that he maintained all his life. Due to the hype surrounding the ASV, he got a copy and began to read it. It was hard going from the start, and he soon had to stop—the Holy Spirit simply would not let him go on. He returned to his trusty AV.

I imagine that at least some of my readers will have a question at this point. Am I implying that anyone who embraced the ASV was not listening to the Holy Spirit when he made that decision? The answer is, "Yes". Obviously, the same holds for the Hortian theory, etc. Unfortunately, few students of theology are in the habit of consulting the Holy Spirit, and those who do are marked for persecution. No Establishment can tolerate anyone who listens to the Holy Spirit. Surely, or have you forgotten John 3:8? "The wind blows where it wishes, and you (sg) hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who has been begotten by the Spirit." Notice that the Lord is saying here that it is **we** who are to be unpredictable, like the wind, or the Spirit ("comes" and "goes" are in the present tense). If you are really under the control of the Spirit you will do unexpected things, just like He does.[1] An Establishment is defined by its 'straitjacket', and the Holy Spirit does not like straitjackets, and vice versa.

In John 8:44 Sovereign Jesus declared that "there is no truth" in Satan, and that he is the father of lying. Since God cannot lie, Titus 1:2, it being contrary to His essence, any and all lies come from the enemy. So what happens if you embrace a lie? You invite Satan into your mind. And what does he do there? He sets up a stronghold that locks you into that lie; you become blind to the truth on that subject.[2] It is a specific application of the truth expressed in 2 Corinthians 4:4—Satan blinds minds. So what happens to our student? With very few exceptions, he succumbs to the pressure exerted by the tools already mentioned. In order to get a job, he has to accept the party line, but that is Mammon, and the Sovereign said that you cannot serve God and Mammon (Matthew 6:24, Luke 16:13). So if you are no longer serving God, you are wide open to Satan. The student accepts the party line, and since it is a lie, Satan goes about blinding him to the truth. If he goes on to become an influential scholar, he will almost certainly come under demonic surveillance (since Satan is

[1] Since Satan is forever muddying the water with excesses and abuses, spiritual discernment is needed.

[2] On that one subject—you will not necessarily be blinded on other subjects, or at least not at first.

not omnipresent).

There is a common misapprehension that trips people up at this point. Since any genuinely regenerated person has the indwelling Holy Spirit, how can Satan or a demon be in that person's mind? There is a fundamental difference between presence and control. Very few Christians have consciously turned over every area of their lives to the control of the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit is a gentleman, he will not take over an area against your will (see John 4:23-24). Any areas not under the Spirit's control are open to the enemy's interference, and most especially if you embrace a lie. By embracing a lie you grieve the Holy Spirit; not wise (Ephesians 4:30). You also resist Him; also not wise (Acts 7:51). So why does God not protect you? Because you rejected the love of the truth, and that turned God against you! When God turns against you, what are your chances? Without God's protection, you become Satan's prey (1 Peter 5:8).[1]

Anyone in rebellion against the Creator is under satanic influence, direct or indirect (in most cases a demon acts as Satan's agent, when something more than the influence of the surrounding culture is required—almost all human cultures have ingredients of satanic provenance; this includes the academic culture). Anyone in rebellion against the Creator will also have strongholds of Satan in his mind. Since Satan is the 'father' of lying (John 8:44), anytime you embrace a lie you invite him into your mind—this applies to any of his sophistries (2 Corinthians 10:5) currently in vogue, such as materialism, humanism, relativism, Marxism, Freudianism, Hortianism, etc.

The selling of the lie is carried on from generation to generation, resulting in a continuous defection. Most professors are 'parrots', simply repeating what they were taught, without ever going back to check the facts. Some older scholars may have become aware of the facts, but because of vested interest they do not mention them to their students; they maintain the party line. This is all part of what we might call 'generational sin'.

There is generational sin within families, in individual churches, in schools, in denominations and across wider segments of the Church. One very serious generational sin that is endemic across wide areas of the conservative/evangelical community at large is the idolatry that elevates human reason above the revealed Word of God. This idolatry expresses itself on many fronts, but perhaps the foundational one relates to the very Text of Scripture itself—I refer to the mentality that constantly calls into

[1] Please keep in mind the sequence of cause and effect—it begins with the rejection of the love of the truth. It is not enough to merely 'accept' the truth, one must love it. For those who have embraced a lie, the only 'medicine' is to return to the love of the truth, rejecting the lie. God may require a public renunciation of the lie.

question the very wording of the Text, thereby undermining confidence in its integrity and authority.

The phrase 'generational sin' implies that a whole generation is practicing that sin. It involves a very serious consequence: all subsequent generations receive that sin as part of their 'gene pool'; it is not perceived as 'sin', but as 'truth'. But being in fact a lie, it becomes a stronghold of Satan in their minds and is not questioned. The only deliverance from that sin comes when someone goes back to its beginning and analyzes and exposes the false presuppositions and reasoning that gave rise to the sin. But such a person should not expect to be well received. He will certainly be persecuted by the 'Establishment'. However, if he has a means of disseminating his findings, he can influence the future.

A solution for the problem

It remains to comment again on 2 Thessalonians 2:9-12, using my translation:

> That one's coming is according to the working of Satan with all power[1] and signs and lying wonders, 10 and with all wicked deception among those who are wasting themselves, because they did not receive the love of the truth[2] so that they might be saved.[3] 11 Yes, because of this God will send them an active delusion so that they will believe the lie[4] 12 and so that all may be condemned who have not believed the truth but have taken pleasure in wickedness.[5]

Notice the sequence: first they reject the love of the truth; it is as a consequence of that choice that God sends the delusion. The implication is that there is a point of no return; God sends the delusion so that they may be

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[1] When Satan fell, he did not lose his power.

[2] The use of the verb 'receive' clearly implies an act of volition on their part; that love was offered or made available to them but they did not want it; they wanted to be able to lie and to entertain lies told by others. But the consequences of such a choice are terrible; they turned their back on salvation.

[3] Since there are only two spiritual kingdoms in this world, that of Sovereign Jesus and that of Satan, "those who are wasting themselves", in this text, are still in Satan's kingdom and therefore wide open to his "wicked deception". The Text states plainly that they are wasting themselves "because they did not receive the love of the truth so that they might be saved". They are not saved.

[4] Perhaps "the lie" is best illustrated in our day by the theory of evolution: 'There is no Creator'—so there will not be any accounting; so you can do what you feel like. How terrible will be the awakening!

[5] "Taking pleasure in wickedness" involves rejecting the Truth of a moral Creator who will demand an accounting, or even overt rebellion against that Creator (like Lucifer/Satan).

condemned. The only intelligent choice is to embrace the truth!

Consider with me the consequences of the facts enunciated in verses 10-12 for a whole nation, like Brazil, where I now live. We have many thousands of local churches that call themselves Christian. But I know of almost none that could be characterized as 'loving the truth'. No one wants a Bible with objective authority. Humanistic, relativistic, materialistic values have taken over the churches. Biblical values are no longer acceptable. In consequence, Satan has control of the government, of education, of health services, of commerce, of the entertainment industry, in short, of the whole culture. The churches that have rejected biblical values are part of the problem—since they have rejected "the love of the truth", they have been taken over by "active delusion".

Note that God Himself sends that delusion with the declared objective of condemning all those who believed the lie. If God Himself visits "active delusion" upon a whole country, what possible escape is there? The only possible 'medicine' is "the love of the truth". Those of us who consider ourselves to be true subjects of Sovereign Jesus need to appeal to Him to show us how to promote the love of the truth to the churches and to the society at large. Here in Brazil it may be too late, but if God's grace still offers us a window of opportunity, we must devote ourselves to promoting the love of the truth by all possible means.

But to return to the stated subject of this article: what I have said about Brazil applies to textual critics as well. Since eclectic textual criticism is based on falsehoods, it belongs to Satan. Since most theological seminaries and Bible schools teach eclectic textual criticism, even the most conservative ones, and since that is the only option that they teach, most students graduate thinking that is all there is. The graduate may believe the NT to be inspired and inerrant in the autographs, but he uses, and teaches from, an eclectic Greek text and modern versions based on an eclectic text. He embraced a lie because he trusted the teachers who assured him that it was the truth. But that lie has become a stronghold of Satan in his mind, which is why so many evangelicals seem to be unable to reconsider what they were taught. Far worse, if God Himself sends active delusion into their minds, because they embraced a lie, how can they escape? However, God is just, and will take all relevant factors into account. Someone who is determined to teach and defend the lie is probably in a bad way.

Now then, any solution for the problem must be pursued in the spiritual realm. People will not change unless the malignant interference in their minds is cancelled. So then, on what basis might we neutralize interference? The most fundamental question for human life on this planet is that of authority: who has it, to what degree, and on what terms? As the chief

priests said to Jesus, "By what authority are you doing this?" (Luke 20:2). After His death and resurrection Sovereign Jesus said, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me" (Matthew 28:18). So He is perfectly within His rights, clearly competent, to delegate a piece of that authority to us. Consider Luke 10:19: "Take note, I am giving you the authority to trample on snakes and scorpions,[1] and over all the power of the enemy, and nothing at all may harm you." Instead of 'am giving', perhaps 2.5% of the Greek manuscripts, of objectively inferior quality, have 'have given' (as in NIV, NASB, LB, TEV, etc.)—a serious error. Jesus said this perhaps five months before His death and resurrection, addressing the seventy (not just the twelve). The Lord was talking about the future, not the past, a future that includes us!

Consider further John 20:21: Jesus said to them again: "Peace to you! Just as the Father sent me, I also send you." "Just as… so also"—Jesus is sending us just like the Father sent Him. So how did They do it? The Father determined and the Son obeyed: "Behold, I have come to do your will, O God" (Hebrews 10:7). And what was that will? To destroy Satan (Hebrews 2:14) and undo his works (1 John 3:8). Since Jesus did indeed defeat Satan (Colossians 2:15, Ephesians 1:20-21, etc.), but then went back to Heaven, what is left for us is the undoing of his works.[2] It seems

[1] The Lord gives us the authority to "trample snakes and scorpions". Well now, to smash the literal insect, a scorpion, you don't need power from on High, just a slipper (if you are fast, you can do it barefoot). To trample a snake I prefer a boot, but we can kill literal snakes without supernatural help. It becomes obvious that Jesus was referring to something other than reptiles and insects. I understand Mark 16:18 to be referring to the same reality—Jesus declares that certain signs will accompany the believers (the turn of phrase virtually has the effect of commands): they will expel demons, they will speak strange languages, they will remove 'snakes', they will place hands on the sick. ("If they drink…" is not a command; it refers to an eventuality.) But what did the Lord Jesus mean by 'snakes'?

In a list of distinct activities Jesus has already referred to demons, so the 'snakes' must be something else. In Matthew 12:34 Jesus called the Pharisees a 'brood of vipers', and in 23:33, 'snakes, brood of vipers'. In John 8:44, after they claimed God as their father, Jesus said, "You are of your father the devil". And 1 John 3:10 makes clear that Satan has many other 'sons' (so also Matthew 13:38-39). In Revelation 20:2 we read: "He seized the dragon, the ancient serpent, who is a slanderer, even Satan, who deceives the whole inhabited earth, and bound him for a thousand years." If Satan is a snake, then his children are also snakes. So then, I take it that our 'snakes' are human beings who have chosen to serve Satan, who have sold themselves to evil. I conclude that the 'snakes' in Luke 10:19 are the same as those in Mark 16:18, but what of the 'scorpions'? Since they also are of the enemy, they may be demons, in which case the term may well include their offspring, the humanoids (for more on this see my article, "As were the Days of Noah", available from www.prunch.org). I am still working on the question of just how the removal is done.

[2] For more on this subject see my article, "Biblical Spiritual Warfare", available from www.prunch.org, or in my book, *Essays on Discipleship, Missions and Spiritual Warfare*, 2nd edition (it also contains 'Days of Noah').

clear to me that to undo any work we must also undo its consequences (to the extent that that may be possible).

Consider also Ephesians 2:4-6: "But God—being rich in mercy, because of His great love with which He loved us, even when we were dead in our transgressions—made us alive together with Christ (by grace you have been saved) and raised us up together and seated us together in the heavenly realms in Christ Jesus." This is tremendous! Here we have our authority. Christ is now seated at the Father's right, 'far above' the enemy and his hosts. This verse affirms that we who are in Christ are there too! So in Christ we also are far above the enemy and his hosts.[1] Surely, or is that not what is stated in Ephesians 1:16-21?

I really do not stop giving thanks for you, making mention of you in my prayers: that the God of our Lord, Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give you the spirit of wisdom and revelation in the real knowledge[2] of Himself, the eyes of your heart having been enlightened, that you may know what is the hope of His[F] calling, and what the riches of the glory of His inheritance in the saints, and what the exceeding greatness of His power into[3] us who are believing, according to the demonstration of the extent of His might which He exercised in the Christ when He raised Him[S] from among the dead and seated Him at His[F] right, in the heavenly realms, far above every ruler and authority and power and dominion—even every name that can be named, not only in this age but also in the next.

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[1] We should be consciously operating on that basis, but since few churches teach this, most Christians live in spiritual defeat.

[2] I finally settled on 'real knowledge' as the best way to render επιγνωσις, the heightened form of *γνωσις*, 'knowledge'. Real knowledge is more than mere intellectual knowledge, or even true theoretical knowledge—it involves experience. The Text goes on to say, "the eyes of your heart having been enlightened". Real knowledge changes your 'heart', who you are.

[3] "Into us"—that is what the Text says. Note that 'believing' is in the present tense. Consider Ephesians 3:20. "Now to Him who is able to do immeasurably more than all we ask or imagine, according to the power that is working in us." Note that "is working" is also in the present tense; having believed yesterday won't hack it, we must believe today. This tremendous power that God pours into us, as we believe, exceeds our powers of imagination. Well now, my personal horizon is limited and defined by my ability to imagine. Anything that I cannot imagine lies outside my horizon, and so obviously I won't ask for it. I sadly confess that I have not yet arrived at a spiritual level where I can unleash this power—I have yet to make the truth in this verse work for me. But I understand that the truth affirmed here is literal, and I only hope that others will get there before I do (so I can learn from them), if I keep on delaying. The whole point of the exercise (verse 21) is for God to get glory, and to the extent that we do <u>not</u> put His power in us to work we are depriving Him of glory that He could and should have.

Now then, "far above every ruler and authority and power and dominion—even every name that can be named, not only in this age but also in the next" must include Satan and his angels. If Christ, seated at the Father's right, is "**far** above" them, and we are in Him, seated at the Father's right, then we too are above all the hosts of the enemy. That is our position and authority for neutralizing interference.

Well and good, but just how are we to go about doing it? The religious professionals (church leaders, seminary professors, etc.) are part of the problem, so we may not look to them to do anything. The few who are not bound by Satan do not know what to do, or are afraid to act. It follows that any solution for the problem must be pursued by sincere followers of Sovereign Jesus with other and different occupations. What follows is written for such followers. If you are one of them, you should ask the Holy Spirit what He wants you to do in your specific situation.

To continue, at what level should we 'neutralize'? The candidates that suggest themselves are: institutions, teachers, students, church leaders, and lay people. How about working at all levels? Next, what procedures are at our disposal to do the neutralizing? I offer the following: a) forbid any further use of Satan's power, in a specific case; b) claim the undoing of the consequences of the use of that power that there has been (to the extent it may be possible); c) destroy any strongholds of Satan in their minds (including blind spots); d) bind any demons involved and send them to the Abyss, forbidding any further demonic activity; e) take their thoughts captive to the obedience of Christ. In my experience, to be efficient we need to be specific: name the institution; name the person.

But just a minute, I submit for consideration that faith is a basic prerequisite for making use of our position and authority. The theological training that I myself received programmed me not to expect supernatural manifestations of power in and through my life and ministry. As a result, I personally find it to be difficult to exercise the kind of faith that the Lord Jesus demands. Consider:

In Matthew 8:5-13 the centurion understood about authority—he gave orders and they were obeyed, promptly and without question.[1] But the Lord Jesus said he had unusually great faith—faith in what? Faith in the Lord's spiritual authority; He could simply give an order and it would happen. Perhaps we should understand this sort of faith as an absolute confidence, without a taint of doubt or fear. In Matthew 21:21 the Lord

[1] The centurion did not say, "In the authority of Rome…", he just said, "Do this; do that." The Lord Jesus did not say, "In the authority of the Father…", He just said, "Be clean! Go!" In Luke 10:19 He said, "I give you the authority over all the power of the enemy"—so we have the authority, so it is up to us to speak! Just like Jesus did.

said, "Assuredly… if you have faith and do not doubt" (see Mark 11:23, "does not doubt in his heart") you can (actually "will") shrivel a tree or send a mountain into the sea. See also Hebrews 10:22, "full assurance of faith", 1 Timothy 2:8, "pray… without doubting", James 1:6, "ask in faith with no doubting". Mark 5:34 and Matthew 15:28 offer positive examples.

If someone gives a commission, they will presumably back it up to the limit of their ability. Since Christ's ability has no limit, His backing has no limit (on His end). In Matthew 28:18 He said, "All authority has been given to me in heaven and on earth." Then comes the commission: "As you go, make disciples… teaching them to obey all things that I have commanded you"—the pronoun refers back to the eleven apostles (verse 16). So what commands had Jesus given the Eleven? Among other things, "heal the sick, cleanse the lepers, cast out demons" (in Matthew 10:8 perhaps 94% of the Greek manuscripts do not have "raise the dead"). The Eleven also heard John 20:21. Knowing that we are being backed by the Sovereign of the universe, who has all authority and power, we can and should act with complete confidence.

A word of caution is necessary at this point. Consider James 4:7—"Therefore submit to God. Resist the devil and he will flee from you." Note the sequence: we need to verify that we are in submission to God before taking on the devil. Then we should claim our position in Christ at the Father's right hand. Since few Christians have received any remotely adequate level of instruction in the area of biblical spiritual warfare (most have received none), I need to explain the procedures.

Forbid any further use of Satan's power:

This procedure is based on Luke 10:19. Sovereign Jesus gives us 'the' authority over all the power of the enemy. Authority controls power, but since we have access to God's limitless power (Ephesians 3:20), we should not give Satan the satisfaction of our using his (and he could easily deceive us into doing things we shouldn't). We should use our authority to forbid the use of Satan's power, with reference to specific situations—in my experience, we must be specific. (I have tried binding Satan once for all until the end of the world, but it doesn't work; presumably because God's plan calls for the enemy's continued activity in this world. We can limit what the enemy does, but not put him completely out of business, or so I deem.) But just how should we go about it?

In the armor described in Ephesians 6 we find "the sword of the Spirit" (verse 17). A sword is a weapon for offense, although it is also used for defense. The Text tells us that this sword is "the ρημα of God"—ρημα, not λογος. It is God's Word spoken, or applied. Really, what good is a

sword left in its sheath? However marvelous our Sword may be (Hebrews 4:12), to produce effect it must come out of the scabbard. The Word needs to be spoken, or written—applied in a specific way.

In the Bible we have many examples where people brought the power of God into action by speaking. Our world began with a creative word from God—spoken (Genesis, 1:3, 6, 9, 11, 14, 20, 24, 26; and see Hebrews 11:3). Moses did a lot of speaking. Elijah spoke (1 Kings 17:1, 18:36-38, 2 Kings 1:10, 12). Elisha spoke (2 Kings 2:14, 21-22, 24; 4:16, 43; 6:18). Jesus did a great deal of speaking. Ananias spoke (Acts 9:17-18). Peter spoke (Acts 9:34, 40). Paul spoke (Acts 13:11; 14:3, 10; 16:18; 20:10; 28:8). In short, we need to speak!

Claim the undoing of the consequences of the use of that power that there has been:

This procedure is based on 1 John 3:8, allied to Luke 10:19. It should be possible for us to command Satan to use his own power to undo messes he has made, thereby obliging him to acknowledge his defeat (which will not sit well with his pride). The Son of God was manifested for the purpose of "undoing the works of the devil" (1 John 3:8), and it is incumbent upon us to continue His work here in this world (John 20:21). How can you undo a work without undoing its consequences as well? The Father sent the Son to undo Satan's works, and the Lord Jesus Christ is sending us to undo Satan's works. Again, I understand that we must be specific.

Destroy any strongholds of Satan in the person's mind:

This procedure is based on 2 Corinthians 10:4 and 1 John 3:8. Since strongholds, and blind spots, in the mind are a work of Satan, and we are here to undo such works, this falls within the area of our competence. It is done by claiming such destruction in so many words, being specific.

Bind any demons involved and send them to the Abyss:

This procedure is based on Mark 3:27 and Luke 8:31. "No one can plunder the strong man's goods, invading his house, unless he first binds the strong man—then he may plunder the house" (Mark 3:27). Since the definite article occurs with 'strong man' the first time the phrase occurs, the entity has already been introduced, so the reference is to Satan. Here is a biblical basis for binding Satan, which is now possible because of Christ's victory. If we can bind Satan, evidently we can also bind any of his subordinates. "And he[1] kept imploring Him that He would not order

[1] The boss demon does most of the talking, representing his cohort.

them to go away into the Abyss" (Luke 8:31).[1] I take it that Jesus did not send them to the Abyss at that time because He had not yet won the victory, and the demons were 'within their rights', under Satan, who was still the god of this world. But the demons were obviously worried! (They knew very well who Jesus was, and what He could do.) I would say that this is one of the 'greater things' (John 14:12) that we may now do—rather, that we should do. As for forbidding any further demonic activity, we have the Lord's example (Mark 9:25), and we are to do what He did (John 14:12).

Take their thoughts captive to the obedience of Christ:

This procedure is based on 2 Corinthians 10:5. In the context, the thoughts are of people who are serving Satan (even if unwittingly). (Of course we should always be checking to be sure that we ourselves are operating within 'the mind of Christ', 1 Corinthians 2:15-16.) Now this procedure moves away from simply neutralizing the enemy's interference, since it introduces a positive 'interference', but it is relevant to the issue being discussed here, since it is protection against falling back into the former error. Again, we must be specific.

Some further texts that may apply: Luke 4:18-21, Psalm 149:5-9, John 14:12.

In Luke 4:18-21 Jesus includes "to set at liberty those who are oppressed" (Isaiah 58:6) as one of the things He was sent to do. Turning to Isaiah 58:6, we find Jehovah stating what kind of 'fast' He would like to see: "To loose the fetters of wickedness [a], to undo the yoke-ropes [b]; to let oppressed ones go free [a], and that you (pl.) break every yoke [b]." As is typical of Hebrew grammar, the two halves are parallel. "To loose the fetters of wickedness" and "to let oppressed ones go free" are parallel. Who placed the "fetters" and who is doing the oppressing? Well, although people can certainly forge their own bonds through their own wicked lifestyle, I take it that the point here is that wicked beings have placed the fetters on others. "To undo yoke-ropes" and "that ye break every yoke" go together. First we should untie the ropes that bind the yoke to the neck, then we should break the yokes themselves. I gain the clear impression that this text is talking about the activity of Satan's servants, men and angels. Using culture, worldview, legal devices, threats, blackmail, lies, deception and just plain demonizing and witchcraft, they bind individuals, families, ethnic groups, etc., with a variety of fetters and instruments of oppression.

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[1] The Text has 'the Abyss', presumably the same one mentioned in Revelation 20:3. The demons knew something that most of us do not.

So what does this have to do with our subject? Well, fasting was an important and required component in their worship of God. So this kind of 'fasting' is something that Jehovah overtly wants to see; it is specifically His will. So when we see any work of Satan in someone's life, it is God's will that we undo it. If we know it is God's will, we can proceed with complete confidence. And it is part of our commission (John 20:21).

Notice also Psalms 149:5-9. "Let the saints exult in glory; let them sing for joy in their beds. Let the high praises of God be in their mouth, and a two-edged sword in their hand—to execute vengeance upon the nations and punishments upon the peoples; to bind their kings with chains and their nobles with fetters of iron; to execute upon them the written judgment. This honor is for all His saints." Note that the saints are in their beds, so the activity described in the subsequent verses must take place in the spiritual realm. I assume that the 'kings' and 'nobles' include both men and fallen angels. The activity described is the prerogative of "all His saints"—if you are one of those saints, it is up to you. There are a number of 'written judgments' in the Text: Zechariah 5:2-4, Proverbs 20:10, Isaiah 10:1-2, Romans 1:26-36 and 1 Corinthians 6:9-10, at least.

In John 14:12 the Lord Jesus said: "Most assuredly I say to you, the one believing into me, he too will do the works that I do; in fact he will do greater works than these, because I am going to my Father." "Most assuredly" is actually "amen, amen"—rendered "verily, verily" in the AV. Only John registers the word as repeated, in the other Gospels it is just "amen". In the contemporary literature we have no example of anyone else using the word in this way. It seems that Jesus coined His own use, and the point seems to be to call attention to an important pronouncement: "Stop and listen!" Often it precedes a formal statement of doctrine or policy, as here.

"The one believing into me, he too will do the works that I do." This is a tremendous statement, and not a little disconcerting. Notice that the Lord said, "will do"; not 'maybe', 'perhaps', 'if you feel like it'; and certainly not 'if the doctrine of your church permits it'! If you believe, you **will do!** The verb 'believe' is in the present tense; if you are believing you will do; it follows that if you are not doing, it is because you are not believing. 2 + 2 = 4. Doing what? "The works that I do." Well, Jesus preached the Gospel, He taught, He cast out demons, He healed all sorts and sizes of sickness and disease, He raised an occasional dead person, and He performed a variety of miracles (water to wine, walk on water, stop a storm instantaneously, transport a boat several miles instantaneously, multiply food, shrivel a tree—and He implied that the disciples should have stopped the storm and multiplied the food, and He stated that they could shrivel a tree [Peter actually took a few steps on water]). So how about

us? The preaching and teaching we can handle, but what about the rest? I once heard the president of a certain Christian college affirm that this verse obviously could not mean what it says because it is not happening! Well, in his own experience and in that of his associates I guess it isn't. But many people today cast out demons and heal. Miracles are also happening. So how about me? And you?

"In fact he will do greater works than these." Well now, if we cast out demons, heal and perform miracles, is that not enough? Jesus wants more, He wants "greater things" than those just mentioned [do not forget what He said in Matthew 7:22-23]. Notice again that He said "will do", not maybe, perhaps, or if your church permits. But what could be 'greater' than miracles? This cannot refer to modern technology because in that event such 'greater things' would not have been available to the believers during the first 1900 years. Note that the key is in the Lord's final statement (in verse 12), "because I am going to my Father". Only if He won could He return to the Father, so He is here declaring His victory before the fact. It is on the basis of that victory that the 'greater things' can be performed. Just what are those 'greater' things? For my answer, see my outline, "Biblical Spiritual Warfare".

In verse 12 the verb 'will do' is singular, both times, so it has to do with the individual. Observe that the Lord did **not** say, "you apostles", "only during the apostolic age", "only until the canon is complete", or whatever. He said, "the one believing", present tense, so this applies to any and all subsequent moments up to our time.[1]

Conclusion

People who deny the existence of the Creator, and therefore of an inspired text, have no reason to participate in the debate (except in an attempt to defend their own disbelief, or if they are knowingly serving Satan). The NT gains its importance by being divinely inspired; if it is not inspired, there is no point in wasting time criticizing its text (it would be irrelevant for today). Even so, most textual critics of the NT do not believe in its divine inspiration. So what motivates them? They remind me of the

[1] Also, to affirm that the miraculous gifts ceased when the last shovelful of dirt fell on the Apostle John's grave is an historical falsehood. Christians who lived during the second, third and fourth centuries, whose writings have come down to us, affirm that the gifts were still in use in their day. No 20th or 21st century Christian, who was not there, is competent to contradict them. And please see the footnote at 1 Corinthians 13:12 in my translation, *The Sovereign Creator Has Spoken*. Any 'cessationist' will have a stronghold of Satan in his mind on that subject, because he has embraced a lie. Any doctrine that derives from reaction against excesses and abuses gives victory to Satan. Any argument designed to justify lack of spiritual power cannot be right.

Sovereign's words in Matthew 23:14 (or 13 in AV). "Woe to you scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! Because you bar *the entrance to* the kingdom of the heavens in the face of the people; for you neither go in *yourselves* nor do you allow those who are trying to enter to go in". Also in Luke 11:52. "Woe to you lawyers! You have taken away the key of knowledge; you yourselves have not entered, and you have hindered those who were entering!" They were really perverse. If they did not want to go in themselves, that was their choice; but to try to stop others was really perverse! Those guys were really dirty.

I am well aware that I have been blunt, that I have used strong language, but I am in good company. Read again Matthew 23:13-33, where Jesus excoriates the scribes and Pharisees. Here is verse 33: "Snakes! Brood of vipers! How can you escape from the condemnation of Hell?" The Lord was more concerned about their eternal destiny (see John 5:34 and 40) than about their sensibilities, their poor feelings, but He was also reacting to the damage that they had inflicted on others. One gains the impression that people simply do not want to take seriously all that the Bible says about God's nature. His love necessarily includes a hatred of evil, because of the damage that evil does to the objects of His love. God is love, but He is also justice and wrath. We have no way of really understanding how terrible was the price that Jehovah the Son paid for our redemption. The Son will not take kindly the despising of His sacrifice. Revelation 19:15 declares that the Son will tread the winepress of the fury of the wrath of the Almighty God all by Himself! It is the Son who will be seated on the Great White Throne,[1] and the wrath on His face will be so terrible that even the heaven will run away (Revelation 20:11)!

People, it is time to stop and think! If God Himself sends active delusion into your mind, you are dead! You are condemned! You absolutely do not want to do anything that could lead God to do that! You absolutely do not want to reject the love of the truth. If you already did, you should fall on your face before God and beg His forgiveness. That is what David did in Psalm 51; he threw himself on God's mercy. He knew perfectly well that there was no sacrifice for what he had done. (The sacrifices prescribed by the Law were only for 'sins of ignorance'.) If you were brainwashed and did not understand what had happened to you, the Just Judge will consider all relevant factors. But you had better have a heart-to-heart talk with Him, and ask Him what you can do toward undoing, or alleviating, the damage that you have inflicted on others.

Conclusion: Since textual criticism exists only for a text considered to be lost, the mere idea of criticizing the NT text is already against Jesus. A

[1] In John 5:22 Jesus declared that the Father has committed all judging to Him.

critic is above the text he is criticizing. I am a NT scholar, not critic; the Text is above me. I have a theory of the preservation of the Text, because the text has never been lost. That said, the fact remains that the extant MSS present us with different readings. We need to collate and study the MSS, but we need a new name for that: I suggest 'Manuscriptology'.

We have historical evidence to support the following statements: 1) the apostles knew they were writing Scripture; 2) the apostles knew that colleagues were writing Scripture; 3) their contemporary Christians immediately recognized that those writings were Scripture; 4) therefore, they were concerned with their protection and preservation; 5) the proliferation of well-made copies started right away; 6) there was a normal transmission of those writings from the beginning and down through the centuries; 7) thus, the original wording was never lost. Further, I believe that I have demonstrated that we can, and do know what that wording is, based on an objective, empirical procedure.

All glory to God; He has preserved His Text!

anyone who still believes the allegations contained in the quote from the RSV preface is in fact embracing **canards**.

Evaluating the 'basic principle'

Anyone who studies NT textual criticism will encounter the following statement: The basic principle of textual criticism is: choose the reading that best explains the rise of the others (or something similar). The uninitiated reader probably will not discern that the statement depends on certain presuppositions (that might be fallacious). Textual criticism only exists for texts whose original wording is deemed to be 'lost'. No one does textual criticism on today's newspaper, or last week's news magazine. No one even does textual criticism on the 1611 King James Version, since we still have printed copies thereof. Anyone familiar with the terrain knows that for the last 140 years, or so, the academic world has been dominated by the notion that the original wording of the NT text is in fact 'lost'. That notion is based squarely on Hort's theory. That theory denies: 1) that the NT writings were divinely inspired; 2) that the early Church recognized them to be Scripture; 3) that they received any special care or protection. As a result, by the time that the superstition and credulity of the Christians had elevated the NT writings to the status of 'Scripture', the original wording was irrevocably 'lost', in the sense that no one knew what it was. Therefore, so goes the theory, it is impossible to recover the original wording by using objective criteria; so they appeal to subjective criteria. (It should be obvious to any thinking person that this places the critic above the text. Notice, further, that there is no way of knowing if they have found it.)

The notion that the original wording of the NT text is 'lost' rejects (or at least ignores) the historical evidence that shows that the transmission of the NT writings was basically normal, from the beginning. That notion also rejects the vast majority (90-95%) of the extant NT manuscripts that represent the Byzantine tradition.[1] Having done that, what do the critics have left to work with? They are left with a handful of relatively early MSS that are so disparate that they cannot be grouped. They not only disagree with the majority, they disagree among themselves. They survived because they are so bad that no one wanted to use them. They have neither 'parents' nor 'children', which means that they were private productions and not honest copies; they are not part of a line of transmission.

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[1] Having rejected the divine inspiration of the NT, they of course reject any divine solicitude for that text. Those who deny the very existence of a Sovereign Creator will logically insist that a nonexistent being cannot do anything.

So what do the critics do when those few MSS disagree among themselves? They ask: Which reading best explains the creation of the others? So what criteria do they use to arrive at that conclusion? They ask questions like these:

1) Which is the oldest MS?
2) Which is the 'best' MS?
3) Which is the shorter reading?
4) Which is the 'harder' reading?
5) Which reading best agrees with the author's style and purpose?

Question 1) is based on the analogy of a stream, whose water will be purest at the source; the greater the distance from the source, the more contaminants the water will have. However, with reference to NT MSS the analogy is certainly false. It is generally agreed that most of the damage suffered by the NT text had happened by the year 200, the date ascribed to our earliest MSS of any size (P^{66}). So our earliest MSS could be full of 'damage'.

Question 2): They generally declare Codex B (Vaticanus, 03) to be the 'best' extant MS. What is the basis for their claim? Hort, based on his subjective preferences (including the early date), declared B to be by far the 'best' MS, and subsequent critics have generally fallen in line with that dictum. But is there any objective basis for the claim? So far as I know, there is none; the objective evidence available says the contrary. (My evaluation applies to all other early MSS as well.)

Questions 3) and 4) are totally naturalistic, excluding any theological or supernatural considerations whatsoever. Hort imported them from the Alexandrian school's procedure for arriving at the original wording of Homer. Anyone who has collated any number of NT MSS, as I have done, knows that those criteria are false. With reference to the NT, the 'harder' reading criterion is obviously perverse.

Question 5) is totally subjective, subject to the critic's whim, bias, theoretical orientation, personal perversity, or whatever. This criterion is unacceptable on its face. Why should any servant of Satan be allowed to determine the wording of the Text, based on his personal preference?

Anyone who respects objective evidence should reject the five criteria discussed above. Anyone who respects objective evidence should understand that the transmission of the NT Text was basically normal, and that the mass of extant MSS must be accorded the respect that they deserve. All the extant MSS deserve to be collated, thereby allowing us to group

them empirically. The empirically defined families must then be compared and evaluated. The canard, 'MSS should be weighed, not counted', is a cop-out.

f[35] Subgroups in the General Epistles[1]

There are fourteen significant splits in the Family in the four larger books (there being none in the three shorter ones), as follows:

James 2:13	ελεον 432[alt], 1766[c]
	ελεος 328, 394 {432, 604}[2] 634, 664, 928, 986, 1247, 1249, 1482, 1548, 1619[c], 1636, 1725, 1732[alt], 1749, 1752, 1766, 1897, 2080, 2221, 2289, 2587, 2704
James 2:14	εχει
	εχη 141, 328, 386, 394, 604, 634, 664, 801, 928, 986, 1075, 1247, 1249, 1250, 1482, 1508, 1548, 1656, 1704, 1737, 1746, 1748, 1749, 1752, 1766, 1855, 1876, 1899, 2218, 2221, 2289, 2431, 2501, 2587, 2626, 2704
1 Peter 1:23	αλλ
	αλλα {149, 201} {432, 604} 757, 824, 1072, 1075, 1248, 1250, 1503, 1548, 1617, 1618, 1619, 1628, 1636, 1637, 1656, 1740, 1745, 1746, 1748, 1754, 1763, 1768, 1864, 1892, 2352, 2431, 2777
1 Peter 2:11	απεχεσθαι 1072[alt]
	απεχεσθε {149, 201} 204, 604[c], 757[alt], 824, 1072, 1248, 1503[c], 1548, 1617, 1618, 1619[alt], 1628[alt], 1637[c], 1745[alt], 1746, 1748, 1864[alt], 1899, 2352, 2431, 2704, 2777
1 Peter 2:24	απογενομενοι
	απογεννωμενοι (328)[3] 394 {432 (604)} 664, 928, 986, 1247, 1249, 1482, 1508, 1548, 1752, 1763, 1766, 1768, 1855, 2289, 2587 (2704)
1 Peter 3:6	εγενηθητε 1766[v]
	εγεννηθητε 604, 664, 801, 1247, 1250, 1618, 1637, 1732, 1748, 1752, 1763, 1876, 1899, 2289, 2431, 2587, 2626, 2704, 2777
1 Peter 4:2	του 2261[c]
	--- {149, 201} {432, 604} 757, 824, 1072, 1075, 1101, 1248, 1503, 1508[c], 1548, 1617, 1618, 1619, 1628, 1636, 1637, 1656, 1737, 1740, 1745, 1746, 1748, 1754, 1761, 1766, 1768, 1864, 1892, 1899, 2218, 2261, 2352, 2431, 2501, 2777
1 Peter 4:11	ως 1748[?]

[1] This study uses 77 out of 84 known family members; the seven that are missing would probably make little, if any, difference to our conclusions. Out of the 77 MSS, all of those not listed with the alternate go with the main form. Thus in James 2:14, the 36 MSS that have the alternate should be subtracted from 77, which leaves 41 for the main form.

[2] MSS within braces, { }, have a common exemplar and may be treated as a single vote.

[3] A MS within ( ) has a slight variation on the given form.

Greek MSS in Italy and Palestine—who would use them?). In lists of early Church 'fathers' Jerome is usually listed with those who wrote in Latin, not Greek. The statement attributed to him is patently false, scientifically impossible; and he would have been ridiculously unqualified to make it. Not being stupid or dishonest, he didn't!

Addendum

After I circulated the above as my 'mailing 75', my Canadian friend, Charles Holm, called my attention to historical research done by Timothy David Barnes that is relevant to the credibility of Jerome (*Tertullian: A Historical and Literary Study*, Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1971). In an appendix dealing specifically with Jerome, there is a section called "Jerome and Eusebius" wherein Barnes offers the following observations (pages 236-238).

> First, Jerome never questions the reliability of Eusebius. Thus he accepts Eusebius' interpretation of what a writer says without asking whether it is correct.
>
> …
>
> Secondly, Jerome far surpasses Eusebius in credulity. What was in Eusebius presented as surmise or mere rumour is for Jerome established and indubitable fact.
>
> …
>
> Thirdly, Jerome mistranslates and misunderstands.
>
> …
>
> Fourthly, Jerome dishonestly conceals both his ignorance and his debt to Eusebius.

Well, well, well, it appears that one should read Jerome with a full salt shaker to hand. Perhaps my closing sentence above should have been: Not being stupid, he didn't! However, I continue to insist that Jerome could not have been so grossly stupid and/or dishonest as to make the ridiculous statement attributed to him. Down with **forgery**![1]

Defining 'Preservation'

We understand that the human authors of Scripture wrote under inspiration, by which we mean that the Holy Spirit superintended the process with the result that they wrote just what He wanted them to write (respecting the norms that rule the use of language). The authors were inspired, protected from error, but not the copyists down through the years. There

[1] For detailed documentation and an exhaustive discussion of other aspects of this question, see Burgon, *The Last Twelve Verses according to S. Mark,* pp. 19-31, 38-69, 265-90.

is nothing like actually collating a number of MSS to give one an appreciation for the divine preservation of the Text, a process more complicated than inspiration. (Satan was not allowed to interfere in the inspiring, but was in the preserving.)

The purpose of this note is to 'chew' a bit on the question of just how to evaluate a copy's representation of its archetypal form, and hence its preservation thereof. I consider that the following should not be regarded as 'variants', or deviations from the archetype:

1. Whether a number is written out or given with the letters;
2. Whether a letter (*alpha*) is written out or given with the letter;
3. Abbreviations or 'shorthand' forms (these are especially frequent at the end of a line), where the identity of the word and its meaning are not touched; the so-called 'nomina sacra' are probably the best known examples.

Both parchment and ink were prepared by hand, and were hard to come by, so any legitimate means of economizing those materials would be viewed as entirely appropriate. This attitude is reflected in the first three items.

4. Copyists would often give expression to an artistic bent with the top line of a page and the end of lines, using flourishes, curlicues, exaggerated forms, lines running off the page, and such—these should be ignored.
5. Alternate spellings of the same word, where the identity of the word and its meaning are not touched. This one is a bit more bothersome than the others, but I think it should be included in the list. However, such differences can be useful in identifying subgroups. I include here alternate spellings of a transliterated foreign word, as in Mark 5:41 (the more so, in this case, since it is translated).
6. Where the order of words is changed, but that change does not affect the meaning in any way (apparently), they are two ways of saying the same thing. Such are not 'proper' variants, although they may be useful in identifying subgroups. Some changes in word order do affect the nuance, so each case needs to be evaluated individually. For example: in Luke 10:41, is it ο Ιησους ειπεν αυτη, or is it ~ 3412? Both mean simply "Jesus said to her".

I am changing the way I describe the performance of MSS with reference to their archetype. A MS that reproduces the archetypal form without any variants is a copy that represents the archetype perfectly. A MS that has only different ways of saying the same thing is a copy that represents the

archetype completely. In this second category I include MSS that have only alternate forms and/or corrections to the archetypal form—the true reading is preserved in every case. I also include here the repeating of a letter or syllable going from one line to the next (not a 'proper' variant in any case).

Of course, when printing a text a choice must be made between competing forms [I am prepared to explain mine in every case], but since the meaning is not touched, such choices will mainly be of concern to someone wishing to apply a numeric code to the text. **The sort of changes listed above may not legitimately be used to argue against the doctrine of inerrancy.**

Collated f^{35} Manuscripts[1]

When I say that a MS had a perfect exemplar (a perfect copy of the family archetype), I did not charge what appear to be a copy's private errors to its exemplar—that includes corrections to the archetype. Of course my judgment is presumed, of necessity, since I have no way of knowing what actually happened; but I am probably not far off. When I say that a copy is itself perfect, I refer to the first hand. I have used the GA numbers, except for Iviron 2110, that has no GA number. Those who are acquainted with my work know that the family's archetypal form has been empirically determined, being the consensus of the collated MSS.

Matthew—I have collated 58 $\mathbf{f^{35}}$ MSS; 1046 and 2554 are perfect; 1072, 1117, 1461, 1496, 1652, 1713, Iviron 2110 had a perfect exemplar (presumed).

Mark—I have collated 61 $\mathbf{f^{35}}$ MSS; none is perfect; GA 867 is complete, virtually perfect; GA 35 also is complete;[2] 586, 2382 had a perfect exemplar.

Luke—I have collated 55 $\mathbf{f^{35}}$ MSS; none is perfect; 2382 is virtually complete;[3] 789, 897 had a perfect exemplar.

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[1] This was the situation in June, 2023.

[2] GA 586; in 10:35 the sons of Zebedee are making a request: "Teacher, we want you to do for us whatever we (ημιν) may ask". Instead of that, 586 has: "Teacher, we want you to do for us whatever ye (υμιν) may ask"—manifest nonsense. The two letters received the same pronunciation, so someone hearing the text read would understand the first person without question. Even someone reading the text would perceive the obvious error and correct the text in his mind. Since 586 has only this one variant for the whole book, one letter, it is virtually perfect.

[3] In 2:40, instead of επ αυτω, it has επ αυτο (there is a split in the family at this point). The preposition επι works with both the dative and the accusative cases, and the

consider that he was handling Scripture (so why did he bother to do it?), in stark contrast to one copying a Family 35 manuscript. (If you were the Holy Spirit, which one would you aid and protect?)

Papyrus 66 is one of the oldest manuscripts of any size that we have (a. 200 AD), and yet it is one of the worst: it has an average of two mistakes per verse! It was so bad that it could not be used, and was buried in desert sand. Indeed, all of the earliest manuscripts of the NT are of poor quality, in varying degrees. The two great early codices, Vaticanus and Sinaiticus, disagree between themselves over 3,000 times, just in the four Gospels (which number does **not** include itacisms and alternate spellings). They are obviously fabricated copies.

To conclude: when evaluating the credibility of Greek manuscripts (copies) of the New Testament, a clear distinction needs to be made between deliberate and careless errors, or variant readings (although the line can be fuzzy). Any honest copyist can, and usually will, make inadvertent mistakes (weariness, distractions). A copyist who makes deliberate changes is serving an ulterior motive. **Any manuscript that is not part of a line of transmission is a fabricated copy, not an honest one.**

Is NT Textual Criticism a Science?

Have you ever heard or read (or said) the phrase, 'the science of NT textual criticism'? How about the phrase, 'textual critic'? So what does a critic do? He criticizes. What does he criticize? In this case it is the text of the NT in Greek. But just what is he criticizing? A literary critic looks at things like style and choice of vocabulary; a commentator tries to decide what was the meaning intended by the author of the text. So what does a textual critic do? He attempts to reconstruct the original wording of a text—notice that he is assuming that the original wording is 'lost', in the sense that no one knows for sure what it is, or was. (Notice also that this places the critic above the text, to which I will return.) Textual criticism only exists for texts whose original wording is deemed to be 'lost'. No one does textual criticism on today's newspaper, or last week's news magazine. No one even does textual criticism on the 1611 King James Version, since we still have printed copies thereof. Any and all arguments surrounding the KJV come under other headings; they are not textual criticism.

Anyone familiar with the terrain knows that for the last 150 years (at least) the academic world has been dominated by the notion that the original wording of the NT text is in fact 'lost'. Just to illustrate, some 65 years ago Robert M. Grant wrote, "it is generally recognized that the original

text of the Bible cannot be recovered".[1] For a number of further references echoing that sentiment please see pages 3-4 of my *Identity IV*. Before attempting to rebut that fiction [canard?], as I believe, I will sketch a bit of relevant history.

A Bit of Relevant History

The discipline as we know it is basically a 'child' of Western Europe and its colonies; the Eastern Orthodox Churches have generally not been involved. (They have always known that the true Text lies within the Byzantine tradition.) In the year 1500 the Christianity of Western Europe was dominated by the Roman Catholic Church, whose pope claimed the exclusive right to interpret Scripture. That Scripture was the Latin Vulgate, which the laity was not allowed to read. Martin Luther's 95 theses were posted in 1517. Was it mere chance that the first printed Greek Text of the NT was published the year before?

As the Protestant Reformation advanced, it was declared that the authority of Scripture exceeded that of the pope, and that every believer had the right to read and interpret the Scriptures. The authority of the Latin Vulgate was also challenged, since the NT was written in Greek. Of course the Vatican library held many Greek MSS, no two of which were identical (at least in the Gospels), so the Roman Church challenged the authenticity of the Greek Text. In short, the Roman Church forced the Reformation to come to grips with textual variation among the Greek MSS. But they did not know how to go about it, because this was a new field of study and they simply were not in possession of a sufficient proportion of the relevant evidence.[2] (They probably did not even know that the Mt. Athos peninsula with its twenty monasteries existed.)

In 1500 the Roman Catholic Establishment was corrupt, morally bankrupt, and discredited among thinking people. The Age of Reason and humanism were coming to the fore. More and more people were deciding that they could do better without the god of the Roman Establishment. The new imagined freedom from supernatural supervision was intoxicating, and many had no interest in accepting the authority of Scripture (*'sola Scriptura'*). Further, it would be naive in the extreme to exclude the

[1] R.M. Grant, "The Bible of Theophilus of Antioch", *Journal of Biblical Literature*, LXVI (1947), 173. Notice the pessimism, it 'cannot be recovered'. In that event, the critics are wasting their time, and ours. Surely, because we would have no way of knowing whether or not they have found it.

[2] Family 35, being by far the largest and most cohesive group of MSS, was poorly represented in the libraries of Western Europe. For that matter, very few MSS of whatever text-type had been sufficiently collated to allow for any tracing of the transmissional history.

supernatural from consideration, and not allow for satanic activity behind the scenes—Ephesians 2:2.[1] 'Sons of the disobedience' joined the attack against Scripture. The so-called 'higher criticism' denied divine inspiration altogether. Others used the textual variation to argue that in any case the original wording was 'lost', there being no objective way to determine what it may have been (that is, they could not perceive such a way at that time).

The uncritical assumption that 'oldest equals best' was an important factor and became increasingly so as earlier uncials came to light. Both Codex Vaticanus and Codex Bezae were available early on, and they have thousands of disagreements, just in the Gospels (in Acts, Bezae is wild almost beyond belief). **If** 'oldest equals best', and the oldest MSS are in constant and massive disagreement between/among themselves, then the recovery of a lost text becomes hopeless. Did you get that? **Hopeless, totally hopeless**! However, I have argued that 'oldest equals worst', and that changes the picture, radically.[2]

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[1] Strictly speaking the Text has "according to the Aeon of this world, according to the ruler of the domain of the air"—the phrases are parallel, so 'Aeon' and 'ruler' have the same referent, a specific person or being. This spirit is presently at work (present tense) in 'the sons of the disobedience'. 'Sons' of something are characterized by that something, and the something in this case is 'the' disobedience (the Text has the definite article)—a continuation of the original rebellion against the Sovereign of the universe. Anyone in rebellion against the Creator is under satanic influence, direct or indirect (in most cases a demon acts as Satan's agent, when something more than the influence of the surrounding culture is required—almost all human cultures have ingredients of satanic provenance; this includes the academic culture [the academic requirement that one demonstrate 'acquaintance with the literature' obliges one to waste time on all that Satan's servants have written—consider 1 Corinthians 3:18-20]). Anyone in rebellion against the Creator will also have strongholds of Satan in his mind. Since Satan is the 'father' of lies (John 8:44), anytime you embrace a lie you invite him into your mind—this applies to any of his sophistries (2 Corinthians 10:5) currently in vogue, such as materialism, humanism, relativism, Marxism, Freudianism, Hortianism, etc.

[2] The benchmark work on this subject is Herman C. Hoskier's *Codex B and its Allies, a Study and an Indictment* (2 vols.; London: Bernard Quaritch, 1914). The first volume (some 500 pages) contains a detailed and careful discussion of hundreds of obvious errors in Codex B; the second (some 400 pages) contains the same for Codex Aleph. He affirms that in the Gospels alone these two MSS differ well over 3,000 times, which number does not include minor errors such as spelling (II, 1). Well now, simple logic demands that one or the other has to be wrong those 3,000+ times; they cannot both be right, quite apart from the times when they are both wrong. **No amount of subjective preference can obscure the fact that they are poor copies, objectively so**.

John William Burgon personally collated what in his day were 'the five old uncials' (ℵ,A,B,C,D). Throughout his works he repeatedly calls attention to the *concordia discors*, the prevailing confusion and disagreement, which the early uncials display between themselves. Luke 11:2-4 offers one example.

"The five Old Uncials" (ℵABCD) falsify the Lord's Prayer as given by St. Luke

Since everyone is influenced (not necessarily controlled) by his milieu, this was true of the Reformers. In part (at least) the Reformation was a 'child' of the Renaissance, with its emphasis on reason. Recall that on trial Luther said he could only recant if convinced by Scripture and reason. So far so good, but many did not want Scripture, and that left only reason. Further, since reason cannot explain or deal with the supernatural, those who emphasize reason are generally unfriendly toward the supernatural. [To this day the so-called historic or traditional Protestant denominations have trouble dealing with the supernatural.]

Before Adolf Deissmann published his *Light from the Ancient East* (1910), (being a translation of *Licht vom Osten*, 1908), wherein he demonstrated that Koiné Greek was the *lingua franca* in Jesus' day, there even being a published grammar explaining its rules, only classical Greek was taught in the universities. But the NT is written in Koiné. Before Deissmann's benchmark work, there were two positions on the NT Greek: 1) it was a debased form of classical Greek, or 2) it was a 'Holy Ghost' Greek, invented for the NT. The second option was held mainly by pietists; the academic world preferred the first, which raised the natural question: if God were going to inspire a NT, why wouldn't He do it in 'decent' Greek?

All of this placed the defenders of an inspired Greek Bible on the defensive, with the very real problem of deciding where best to set up their defense perimeter. Given the prevailing ignorance concerning the relevant evidence, their best choice appeared to be an appeal to Divine Providence. God providentially chose the TR, so that was the text to be used (the 'traditional' text).[1]

To all appearances Satan was winning the day, but he still had a problem: the main Protestant versions (in German, English, Spanish, etc.) were all based on the *Textus Receptus*, as were doctrinal statements and 'prayer books'. Enter F.J.A. Hort, a quintessential 'son of the disobedience'. Hort

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> in no less than forty-five words. But so little do they agree among themselves, that they throw themselves into six different combinations in their departures from the Traditional Text; and yet they are never able to agree among themselves as to one single various reading: while only once are more than two of them observed to stand together, and their grand point of union is no less than an omission of the article. Such is their eccentric tendency, that in respect of thirty-two out of the whole forty-five words they bear in turn solitary evidence. (*The Traditional Text of the Holy Gospels Vindicated and Established*. Arranged, completed, and edited by Edward Miller. London: George Bell and Sons, 1896, p. 84.)

Yes indeed, oldest equals worst. For more on this subject, please see pages 93-101 in my *Identity VI*.

[1] Please note that I am not criticizing Burgon and others; they did what they could, given the information available to them. They knew that the Hortian theory and resultant Greek text could not be right.

did not believe in the divine inspiration of the Bible, nor in the divinity of Jesus Christ. Since he embraced the Darwinian theory as soon as it appeared, he presumably did not believe in God.[1] His theory of NT textual criticism, published in 1881,[2] was based squarely on the presuppositions that the NT was not inspired, that no special care was afforded it in the early decades, and that in consequence the original wording was lost—lost beyond recovery, at least by objective means. His theory swept the academic world and continues to dominate the discipline to this day.[3]

Moreover, Hort claimed that as a result of his work only a thousandth part of the NT text could be considered to be in doubt, and this was joyfully received by the rank and file, since it seemed to provide assurance about the reliability of that text—however, of course, that claim applied only to the W-H text (probably the worst published NT in existence, to this day).[4]

The Nature of a Scientific Exercise

So much for my sketch of history. I will now return to the question in the title. To begin, I observe and insist that in any scientific exercise a rigorous distinction must be made between evidence, interpretation, and presupposition. It is dishonest to represent one's presuppositions as being part of the evidence (opinion is not evidence). So, if NT textual criticism

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[1] For documentation of all this, and a good deal more besides, in Hort's own words, please see the biography written by his son. A.F. Hort, *Life and Letters of Fenton John Anthony Hort* (2 vols.; London: Macmillan and Co. Ltd., 1896). The son made heavy use of the father's plentiful correspondence, whom he admired. (In those days a two volume 'Life', as opposed to a one volume 'Biography', was a posthumous status symbol.) Many of my readers were taught, as was I, that one must not question/judge someone else's motives. But wait just a minute; where did such an idea come from? It certainly did not come from God, who expects the spiritual person to evaluate everything (1 Corinthians 2:15). Since there are only two spiritual kingdoms in this world (Matthew 12:30, Luke 11:23), then the idea comes from the other side. By eliminating motive, one also eliminates presupposition, which is something that God would never do, since presupposition governs interpretation (Matthew 22:29, Mark 12:24). Which is why we should <u>always</u> expect a true scholar to state his presuppositions. I have repeatedly stated mine, but here they are again: 1) The Sovereign Creator of the universe exists; 2) He delivered a written revelation to the human race; 3) He has preserved that revelation intact to this day.

[2] B.F. Westcott and F.J.A. Hort, *The New Testament in the Original Greek* (2 Vols.; London: Macmillan and Co., 1881). The second volume explains the theory, and is generally understood to be Hort's work.

[3] For a thorough discussion of that theory, please see chapters 3 and 4 in my *Identity V, VI or VII*.

[4] I would say that their text is mistaken with reference to 10% of the words—the Greek NT has roughly 140,000 words, so the W-H text is mistaken with reference to 14,000 of them. I would say that the so-called 'critical' text currently in vogue is 'only' off with reference to some 12,000, an improvement (small though it be). And just by the way, how wise is it to use a NT prepared by a servant of Satan?

is to be a 'science', presuppositions must be excluded. But if we exclude the presupposition that the original wording is 'lost', then textual criticism ceases to exist; and how can you have a 'science' of something that doesn't exist? Science is one thing; theory is another. A theory is based on presupposition, of necessity, so it is legitimate to speak of a Hortian theory of textual criticism, since he considered the original wording to be lost. My own theory does not include textual criticism, since I consider that the original wording is not lost. I defend a theory of the divine preservation of the NT Text.[1]

By now it should be evident to the reader that the question of a 'lost' original is the crux, the central issue in any attempt to identify the original wording of the NT. So to that issue I now turn. To be fair, I need to recognize two definitions of 'lost': 1) lost beyond recovery, at least by objective means; 2) lost from view, in the sense that the available evidence has not been sufficiently studied to permit an empirical choice between /among competing variants. I consider that my *Identity V* provides more than enough evidence to demonstrate that the first definition is false. The Hortian theory and all derivatives thereof, such as eclecticism (of whatever type), is not science, and may not honestly be called science. The second definition allows for scientific procedure. I suggest and recommend that we start using the term 'manuscriptology', rather than 'textual criticism'—manuscriptology refers to the study of the MSS, and is neutral as to presupposition. Any scientific exercise should begin with the evidence; so what is the evidence?

The primary evidence is furnished by the continuous text manuscripts (Greek) of the NT. The evidence furnished by the lectionaries is secondary. The evidence furnished by ancient versions and patristic citations is tertiary. Genuine historical evidence (to the extent that this can be determined) is ancillary. Where the primary evidence is unequivocal, the remaining types should not come into play. For example, at any given point in the four Gospels there will be around 1,700 extant continuous text MSS, representing all lines of transmission and all locales.[2] Where they all agree, there can be no legitimate doubt as to the original wording. But what if an early Papyrus comes to light with a variant, does that change the picture? The very fact of being early suggests that it is bad; why was it not used and worn out?

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[1] I consider myself to be a textual scholar, not critic. The Text is above me, not the opposite. In eclecticism the critic is above the text, is above the evidence; instead of faithfully following the evidence, he makes the evidence follow him. The MSS are reduced to the role of 'supplier of readings'.

[2] Of course we know that there are MSS not yet 'extant', not yet identified and catalogued, so the number can only go up.

We have probably all heard/read the canard, 'manuscripts are to be weighed, not counted'. The basic meaning of the verb 'to weigh' refers to an objective procedure; it is done with physically verifiable weights. But do the followers of Hort (who are the main ones who keep repeating it) 'weigh' manuscripts using objective criteria? They do not, which is why I call it a 'canard'. That said, however, I submit for the consideration of all concerned that it is indeed possible to weigh MSS using objective criteria.

Just how are MSS to be weighed? And who might be competent to do the weighing? As the reader is by now well aware, Hort and most subsequent scholars have done their 'weighing' on the basis of so-called 'internal evidence'—the two standard criteria are, 'choose the reading which fits the context' and 'choose the reading which explains the origin of the other reading'.

One problem with this has been well stated by E.C. Colwell. "As a matter of fact these two standard criteria for the appraisal of the internal evidence of readings can easily cancel each other out and leave the scholar free to choose in terms of his own prejudgments."[1] Further, "the more lore the scholar knows, the easier it is for him to produce a reasonable defense of both readings…"[2] The whole process is so subjective that it makes a mockery of the word 'weigh'. The basic meaning of the term involves an evaluation made by an objective instrument. If we wish our weighing of MSS to have objective validity, we must find an objective procedure.

How do we evaluate the credibility of a witness in real life? We watch how he acts, listen to what he says and how he says it, and listen to the opinion of his neighbors and associates. If we can demonstrate that a witness is a habitual liar or that his critical faculties are impaired then we receive his testimony with skepticism. It is quite possible to evaluate MSS in a similar way, to a considerable extent, and it is hard to understand why scholars have generally neglected to do so.

Can we objectively 'weigh' P^{66} as a witness? (It is the oldest one of any size.) Well, in the space of John's Gospel (not complete) it has over 900 clear, indubitable errors—as a witness to the identity of the text of John it has misled us over 900 times. Is P^{66} a credible witness? I would argue that neither of the scribes of P^{66} and P^{75} knew Greek; should we not say that as witnesses they were impaired?[3]

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[1] Colwell, "External Evidence and New Testament Criticism", *Studies in the History and Text of the New Testament*, eds. B.L. Daniels and M.J. Suggs (Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press, 1967), p. 3.

[2] *Ibid*., p. 4.

[3] The fact that the transcriber of P^{75} copied letter by letter and that of P^{66} syllable by

P^{75} is placed close to P^{66} in date. Though not as bad as P^{66}, it is scarcely a good copy. Colwell found P^{75} to have about 145 itacisms plus 257 other singular readings, 25 percent of which are nonsensical.[1] Although Colwell gives the scribe of P^{75} credit for having tried to produce a good copy, P^{75} looks good only by comparison with P^{66}. (If you were asked to write out the Gospel of John by hand, would you make over 400 mistakes? Try it and see!) It should be kept in mind that the figures offered by Colwell deal only with errors which are the exclusive property of the respective MSS. They doubtless contain many other errors which happen to be found in some other witness(es) as well. In other words, they are actually worse even than Colwell's figures indicate.

P^{45}, though a little later in date, will be considered next because it is the third member in Colwell's study. He found P^{45} to have approximately 90 itacisms plus 275 other singular readings, 10 percent of which are non-sensical (*Ibid*.). However P^{45} is shorter than P^{66} (P^{75} is longer) and so is not comparatively so much better as the figures might suggest at first glance. Colwell comments upon P^{45} as follows:

> Another way of saying this is that when the scribe of P^{45} creates a singular reading, it almost always makes sense; when the scribes of P^{66} and P^{75} create singular readings, they frequently do not make sense and are obvious errors. Thus P^{45} must be given credit for a much greater density of intentional changes than the other two (*Ibid*., p. 376).
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> As an editor the scribe of P^{45} wielded a sharp axe. The most striking aspect of his style is its conciseness. The dispensable word is dispensed with. He omits adverbs, adjectives, nouns, participles, verbs, personal pronouns—without any compensating habit of addition. He frequently omits phrases and clauses. He prefers the simple to the compound word. In short, he favors brevity. He shortens the text in at least fifty places in **singular readings alone**. But he does **not** drop syllables or letters. His shortened text is readable (*Ibid*., p. 383).

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syllable (Colwell, "Scribal Habits", p. 380) suggests strongly that neither one knew Greek. When transcribing in a language you know you copy phrase by phrase, or at the very least word by word. P^{66} has so many nonsensical readings that the transcriber could not have known the meaning of the text. Anyone who has ever tried to transcribe a text of any length by hand (not typewriter) in a language he does not understand will know that it is a taxing and dreary task. Purity of transmission is not to be expected under such circumstances.

[1] E.C. Colwell, "Scribal Habits in Early Papyri: A Study in the Corruption of the Text", *The Bible in Modern Scholarship*, ed. J.P. Hyatt [New York: Abingdon Press, 1965], pp. 374-76.

P^{46} is thought by some to be as early as P^{66}. Zuntz's study of this manuscript is well known. "In spite of its neat appearance (it was written by a professional scribe and corrected—but very imperfectly—by an expert), P^{46} is by no means a good manuscript. The scribe committed very many blunders… My impression is that he was liable to fits of exhaustion."[1]

It should be remarked in passing that Codex B is noted for its 'neat appearance' also, but it should not be assumed that therefore it must be a good copy. Even Hort conceded that the scribe of B "reached by no means a high standard of accuracy" (Westcott and Hort, p. 233). Aleph is acknowledged on every side to be worse than B in every way. Zuntz says further: "P^{46} abounds with scribal blunders, omissions, and also additions" (*Op.Cit.*, p. 212).

> …the scribe who wrote the papyrus did his work very badly. Of his innumerable faults, only a fraction (less than one in ten) have been corrected and even that fraction—as often happens in manuscripts—grows smaller and smaller towards the end of the book. Whole pages have been left without any correction, however greatly they were in need of it (*Ibid.*, p. 252).

Recall from Colwell's study that the scribe of P^{45} evidently made numerous **deliberate** changes in the text—should we not say that he was morally impaired? In any case, he has repeatedly misinformed us. Shall we still trust him? Similarly, it has been demonstrated that Aleph and B have over 3,000 mistakes between them, just in the Gospels. Aleph is clearly worse than B, but probably not twice as bad—at least 1,000 of those mistakes are B's. Do Aleph and B fit your notion of a good witness?[2] Again I say: oldest equals worst!

We really need to understand that age guarantees nothing about quality. Each witness must be evaluated on its own, quite apart from age. Further, and perhaps more to the point, we need to know how a given MS relates to others. Once a MS has been empirically identified as belonging to a family (line of transmission), then it is no longer an independent witness to the original—it is a witness to the family archetype. As Colwell so well put it, "the crucial question for early as for late witnesses is still, 'WHERE DO THEY FIT INTO A PLAUSIBLE RECONSTRUCTION OF THE HISTORY OF THE MANUSCRIPT TRADITION?'"[3]

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[1] Gunther Zuntz, *The Text of the Epistles* (London: Oxford University Press, 1953), p.18.

[2] If you copied the four Gospels by hand, do you think you could manage to make a thousand mistakes? Try it and see!

[3] Colwell, "Hort Redivivus: A Plea and a Program", *Studies in Methodology in Textual Criticism of the New Testament*, E.C. Colwell (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1969), p. 157. [Emphasis in the original.]

Lamentably, the Hortian theory, allied to the fiction that 'oldest equals best', has had a soporific effect upon the discipline such that comparatively few MSS have been fully collated, and in consequence few families have been empirically defined. A rough idea based on spot checking is not adequate; there is too much mixture.

The Transmission of the Text

Going back to the 1,700 extant MSS for any given point in the Gospels, it should be evident that a variant in a single MS, of whatever age, is irrelevant—it is a false witness to its family archetype, at that point, nothing more. If a number of MSS share a variant, but do not belong to the same family, then they made the mistake independently and are false witnesses to their respective family archetypes—there is no dependency. Where a group of MSS evidently reflect correctly the archetypal form of their family, then we are dealing with a family (not the individual MSS). Families need to be evaluated just as we evaluate individual MSS. It is possible to assign a credibility quotient to a family, based on objective criteria. But of course any and all families must first be empirically identified and defined, and such identification depends upon the full collation of MSS.

Although the discipline has (so far) neglected to do its homework (collating MSS), still a massive majority of MSS should be convincing. For example, if a variant enjoys 99% attestation from the primary witnesses, this means that it totally dominates any genealogical 'tree', because it dominated the global transmission of the text. The *INTF Text und Textwert* series, practitioners of the Claremont profile method, H.C. Hoskier, von Soden, Burgon, Scrivener—in short, anyone who has collated any number of MSS—have all demonstrated that the Byzantine bulk of MSS is by no means monolithic. There are any number of streams and rivulets. (Recall that Wisse posited 34 groups within the Byzantine bulk, with 70 subgroups.) It is clear that there was no 'stuffing the ballot box'; there was no 'papal' decree; there was no recension imposed by ecclesiastical authority. In short, the transmission was predominantly normal.

> Under normal circumstances the older a text is than its rivals, the greater are its chances to survive in a plurality or a majority of the texts extant at any subsequent period. But the **oldest** text of all is the autograph. Thus it ought to be taken for granted that, barring some radical dislocation in the history of transmission, a majority of texts will be far more likely to represent correctly the character of the original than a small minority of texts. This is especially true when the ratio is an overwhelming 8:2. Under any reasonably normal transmissional conditions, it would be… quite impossible for a later

text-form to secure so one-sided a preponderance of extant witnesses.[1]

I insist that the transmission of the NT Text was in fact predominantly normal, based on historical evidence. Part I above lists and discusses that evidence, but here is a thumbnail sketch:

1. The authors of the NT books believed they were writing Scripture;
2. The Apostles recognized that their colleagues were writing Scripture;
3. The 'Church Fathers' of the I and II centuries regarded the NT writings as Scripture;
4. The NT writings were used along with the OT by the Christian congregations from very early on;
5. The early Christians were concerned about the purity of the NT Text.
6. What regions started out with the Autographs? Aegean area (18-24), Rome (2-7), Palestine (0-3), Egypt (0).
7. Where was the Church strongest during the II and III centuries? Asia Minor and the Aegean area.
8. Where was Greek used most and longest? Aegean area and Asia Minor.
9. What are the implications of Diocletian's campaign and the Donatist movement?

I submit that the evidence is clear to the effect that the transmission was in fact predominantly normal.

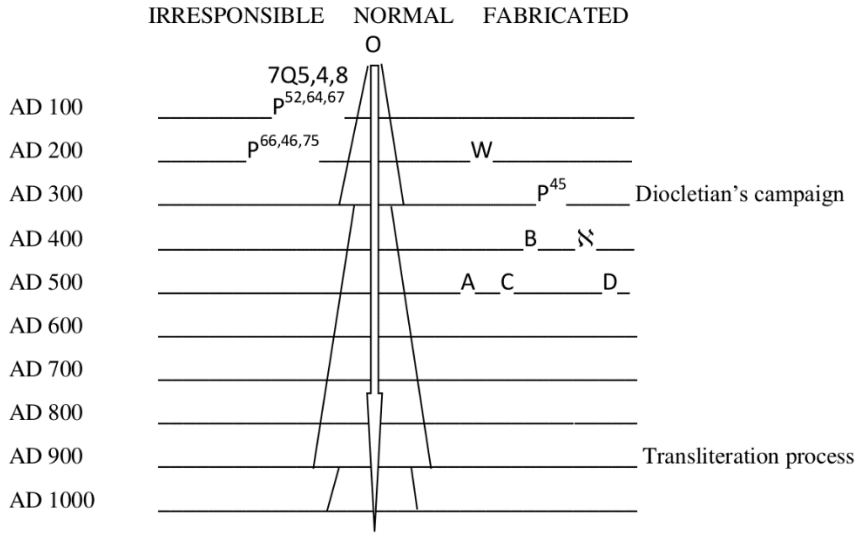
So what sort of a picture may we expect to find in the surviving witnesses, given the understanding that the history of the transmission of the New Testament Text was predominantly normal? We may expect a broad spectrum of copies, showing minor differences due to copying mistakes but all reflecting one common tradition. The simultaneous existence of abnormal transmission in the earliest centuries would result in a sprinkling of copies, helter-skelter, outside of that main stream. The picture would look something like the following figure.[2]

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[1] Z.C. Hodges, "A Defense of the Majority Text" (unpublished course notes, Dallas Theological Seminary, 1975), p. 4. Appendix C in my *Identity IV* shows that the mathematical science of statistical probability gives ample support to Hodges' statement. It is statistically impossible for a late comer to dominate the transmission.

[2] The history of the place where Codex W was found suggests that it must have been copied before AD 200, which would put the Byzantine Text in the second century, since it shows Byzantine influence.

The MSS within the cones represent the 'normal' transmission. To the left I have plotted some possible representatives of what we might style the 'irresponsible' transmission of the text—the copyists produced poor copies through incompetence or carelessness but did not make deliberate changes. To the right I have plotted some possible representatives of what we might style the 'fabricated' transmission of the text—the scribes made deliberate changes in the text (for whatever reasons), producing fabricated copies, not true copies. I am well aware that the MSS plotted on the figure above contain both careless and deliberate errors, in different proportions



(7Q5,4,8 and $P^{52,64,67}$ are too fragmentary to permit the classification of their errors as deliberate rather than careless), so that any classification such as I attempt here must be relative and gives a distorted picture. Still, I venture to insist that ignorance, carelessness, officiousness and malice all left their mark upon the transmission of the New Testament text, and we must take account of them in any attempt to reconstruct the history of that transmission.

As the figure suggests, I argue that Diocletian's campaign had a purifying effect upon the stream of transmission. In order to withstand torture rather than give up your MS(S), you would have to be a truly committed believer, the sort of person who would want good copies of the Scriptures. Thus it was probably the more contaminated MSS that were destroyed, in the main, leaving the purer MSS to replenish the earth (please see the section "Imperial repression of the N.T." on page 106 of my *Identity VI*). The arrow within the cones represents Family 35 (see Part II).

Another consideration suggests itself—if, as reported, the Diocletian campaign was most fierce and effective in the Byzantine area, the numerical advantage of the 'Byzantine' text-type over the 'Western' and 'Alexandrian' would have been reduced, giving the latter a chance to forge ahead. But it did not happen. The Church, in the main, refused to propagate those forms of the Greek text. Codices B, ℵ, D, etc., have no 'children'. Since it is impossible to produce an archetypal form for either the 'Western' or the 'Alexandrian' text-types, so-called, based on manuscript evidence, do they even exist?

The 'Crux' of a 'Lost' Original

Returning to the 'crux', is/was the original wording lost? I answer with an emphatic, "**No**". It certainly exists within the Byzantine bulk, but what do we do if there is confusion within that bulk? (To insist that it must be one of the existing variants is better than nothing, I suppose, but I, at least, want to identify the original wording.) To my mind, any time at least 90% of the primary witnesses agree, there can be no reasonable question; it is statistically impossible that a non-original reading could score that high.[1] Any time a reading garners an attestation of at least 80%, its probability is very high. But for perhaps 2% of the words in the NT the attestation falls below 80% (a disproportionate number being in the Apocalypse), and at this point we need to shift our attention from MSS to families.[2] I have already mentioned assigning a credibility quotient to each family, based on objective criteria, and this needs to be done. Unfortunately, there is a great deal of 'homework' waiting to be done in this area (so far as I know, only Family 35 has an empirically defined profile),[3] but enough work has been done to allow for some rough ideas.

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[1] See Appendix B in my *Identity VI*.

[2] Once all MSS have been collated and have been empirically assigned to families, then we can confine our attention to those families, from the start (as I have done in the Apocalypse).

[3] So far as I know, neither **f^{1}** nor **f^{13}** exists outside of the Gospels, but even there, has anyone ever produced an empirically defined profile for either one? Consider the following statement by Metzger:

> It should be observed that, in accord with the theory that members of f^{1} and f^{13} were subject to progressive accommodation to the later Byzantine text, scholars have established the text of these families by adopting readings of family witnesses that differ from the Textus Receptus. Therefore the citation of the siglum f^{1} and f^{13} may, in any given instance, signify a minority of manuscripts (or even only one) that belong to the family. (*A Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament* [companion to UBS^{3}], p. xii.)

Would it be unreasonable to say that such a proceeding is unfair to the reader? Does it not mislead the user of the apparatus? At least as used by the UBS editions, those sigla do not represent empirically defined profiles.

We are indebted to the *Institut für Neutestamentliche Textforschung* for their *Text und Textwert* series. A careful look at their collations indicates that there probably is no $\mathbf{K^x}$, anywhere (and remember Wisse). Take, for example, the *TuT* volumes on John's Gospel, chapters 1-10. They examined a total of 1,763 MSS (for 153 variant sets) and included the results in the two volumes. Pages 54 - 90 (volume 1) contain "Groupings according to degrees of agreement" "agreeing more often with each other than with the majority text". Only one group symbol is used, $\mathbf{K^r}$—the first representative of the family, MS 18, heads a group of about 120 MSS, but all subsequent representatives have only a $\mathbf{K^r}$ (that I call $\mathbf{f^{35}}$). Following $\mathbf{K^r}$, there are 22 groups with between 52 and 25 MSS, and all but four of them are really $\mathbf{K^r}$ / $\mathbf{f^{35}}$, and the same holds for a number of smaller groups, so their $\mathbf{K^r}$ should probably be over 200 (I would say that Family 35 in the Gospels has over 250 representatives, but their ranking here is based on only 153 variant sets, in half of John).

Consider the largest group apart from $\mathbf{K^r}$: 2103. Of its 52 members, 15 show only a 95% agreement with MS 2103. If those 52 MSS are ever collated throughout the Gospels, it is entirely predictable that the 'group' will shrink considerably; it may even disappear.

Some years ago now, Maurice Robinson did a complete collation of 1,389 MSS that contain the P.A.,[1] and I had William Pierpont's photocopy of those collations in my possession for two months, spending most of that time studying those collations. As I did so, it became obvious to me that von Soden 'regularized' his data, arbitrarily 'creating' the alleged archetypal form for his first four families, $\mathbf{M^{1,2,3,4}}$—if they exist at all, they are rather fluid. His $\mathbf{M^{5\&6}}$ do exist, having distinct profiles for the purpose of showing that they are different, but they are a bit 'squishy', with enough internal confusion to make the choice of <u>the</u> archetypal form to be arbitrary. In fact, I suspect that they will have to be subdivided. In contrast to the above, his $\mathbf{M^7}$ (that I call Family 35) has a solid, unambiguous profile—the archetypal form is demonstrable, empirically determined.

As for the Apocalypse, of the nine groups that Hoskier identified, only his Complutensian (that I call Family 35) is homogenous. Of the others, the main ones all have sub-divisions, that will require their own profile.

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[1] 240 MSS omit the PA, 64 of which are based on Theophylact's commentary. Fourteen others have lacunae, but are not witnesses for total omission. A few others certainly contain the passage but the microfilm is illegible. So, 1389 + 240 + 14 + 7(?) = about 1650 MSS checked by Robinson. That does not include Lectionaries, of which he also checked a fair number. (These are microfilms held by the *Institut* in Münster. We now know that there are many more extant MSS, and probably even more that are not yet 'extant'.) Unfortunately, so far as I know, Robinson has yet to publish his collations, thus making them available to the public at large.

Given my presuppositions, I consider that I have good reason for declaring the divine preservation of the precise original wording of the complete New Testament Text, to this day. That wording is reproduced in my edition of the Greek NT, available from www.prunch.org. BUT PLEASE NOTE: whether or not the archetype of **f^{35}** is the Autograph (as I claim), the fact remains that the MSS collated for this study reflect an incredibly careful transmission of their source, and this throughout the middle-ages. My presuppositions include: God exists; He inspired the Biblical Text; He promised to preserve it for a thousand generations (1 Chronicles 16:15); so He must have an active, ongoing interest in that preservation [there have been fewer than 300 generations since Adam, so He has a ways to go!]. **If He was preserving the original wording in some line of transmission other than f^{35}, would that transmission be any less careful than what I have demonstrated for f^{35}?** I think not. So any line of transmission characterized by internal confusion is disqualified—this includes **all** the other lines of transmission that I have seen so far![1]

On the basis of the evidence so far available I affirm the following:

1. The original wording was never 'lost', and its transmission down through the years was basically normal, being recognized as inspired material from the beginning.
2. That normal process resulted in lines of transmission.
3. To delineate such lines, MSS must be grouped empirically on the basis of a shared mosaic of readings.
4. Such groups or families must be evaluated for independence and credibility.
5. The largest clearly defined group is Family 35.
6. Family 35 is demonstrably independent of all other lines of transmission throughout the NT.
7. Family 35 is demonstrably ancient, dating to the 3rd century, at least.
8. Family 35 representatives come from all over the Mediterranean area; the geographical distribution is all but total.
9. Family 35 is not a recension, was not created at some point subsequent to the Autographs.
10. Family 35 is an objectively/empirically defined entity throughout the NT; it has a demonstrable, diagnostic profile from Matthew 1:1 to Revelation 22:21.

[1] Things like **M^{6}** and **M^{5}** in John 7:53-8:11 come to mind.

11. The archetypal form of Family 35 is demonstrable—it has been demonstrated (see Part II).

12. The Original Text is the ultimate archetype; any candidate must also be an archetype—a real, honest to goodness, objectively verifiable archetype; there is only one—Family 35.[1]

13. God's concern for the preservation of the Biblical Text is evident: I take it that passages such as 1 Chronicles 16:15, Psalm 119:89, Isaiah 40:8, Matthew 5:18, Luke 16:17 and 21:33, John 10:35 and 16:12-13, 1 Peter 1:23-25 and Luke 4:4 may reasonably be taken to imply a promise that the Scriptures (to the tittle) will be preserved for man's use (we are to live "by *every* word of God"), and to the end of the world ("for a thousand generations"), but no intimation is given as to just how God proposed to do it. We must deduce the answer from what He has indeed done—we discover that He **did**!

14. This concern is reflected in Family 35; it is characterized by incredibly careful transmission (in contrast to other lines). [I have a perfect copy of the Family 35 archetypal text for most NT books (22); I have copies made from a perfect exemplar (presumed) for another four (4); as I continue to collate MSS I hope to add the last one (Acts), but even for it the archetypal form is demonstrable.]

15. If God was preserving the original wording in some line of transmission other than Family 35, would that line be any less careful? I think not. So any line of transmission characterized by internal confusion is disqualified—this includes **all** the other lines of transmission that I have seen so far.

16. I affirm that God used Family 35 to preserve the precise original wording of the New Testament Text; it is reproduced in my edition of the Greek Text.[2]

Honesty used to be part of the definition of a true scholar. Anyone who wishes to be one should absolutely stop representing his presuppositions as being part of the evidence. Since the original was never lost, there is no legitimate textual criticism of the NT, and therefore no science of such. Since NT textual criticism (as practiced by the academic community during the past 130 years) depends on a false presupposition, it cannot be

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[1] If you want to be a candidate for the best lawyer in your city, you must be a lawyer, or the best carpenter, or oncologist, or whatever. If there is only one candidate for mayor in your town, who gets elected?

[2] And God used mainly the Eastern Orthodox Churches to preserve the NT Text down through the centuries—they have always used a Text that was an adequate representation of the Original, for all practical purposes.

a science. Those who reject the primary evidence can, and probably will, continue to propound a theory of textual criticism. I suppose they have a right to their theory, but I cannot wish them well.

Aland's Presentation of the Evidence

For this discussion I will use statistics offered by Kurt Aland and his Institute for New Testament Textual Research. Since he despised the Byzantine Text and was a devoted champion of his Egyptian text, we can be absolutely certain that the evidence will not be presented so as to favor the Byzantine Text in any way.

The Uncials

In *The Text of the New Testament*[1] K. Aland offers a summary of the results of a "systematic test collation" for the more important uncials from centuries IV-IX. He uses four headings: "Byzantine", "original", "agreements" between the first two, and "independent or distinctive" readings. Since by "original" he seems to mean essentially "Egyptian" (or "Alexandrian") I will use the following headings: Egyptian, Majority ("Byzantine"), both ("agreements") and other ("independent"). I proceed to chart each MS from the IV through IX centuries for which Aland offers a summary:

By way of explanation: "cont." stands for content, **e** = Gospels (but Aland's figures cover only the Synoptics), **a** = Acts, **p** = Pauline Epistles (including Hebrews) and **c** = Catholic Epistles; "Cat." refers to Aland's five categories (*The Text*, pp. 105-6) and "class." stands for a classification devised by me wherein **E** = Egyptian, **M** = Majority and **O** = other. It has the following values, which are illustrated with M:

M+++++	=	100%				
M++++	=	over 95%	=	19:1	=	very strong
M+++	=	over 90%	=	9:1	=	strong
M++	=	over 80%	=	4:1	=	good
M+	=	over 66%	=	2:1	=	fair
M	=	over 50%	=	1:1	=	weak
M-	=	plurality	=		=	marginal
M/E	=	a tie				

I assume that Aland will agree with me that E + M is certainly original, so the "both" column needs to be disregarded as we try to evaluate the tendencies of the several MSS. Accordingly I considered only the "Egyptian", "Majority" and "other" columns in calculating percentages.

[1] K. and B. Aland, *Ibid*., pp. 106-125.